Between visibility and structural recognition: a mixed-methods exploration of femicide framing in Romanian online news

Mellan synlighet och strukturellt igenkännande: en blandad metodologisk utforskning av kvinnomordsframställningar i rumänska onlinenyheter

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To my Diti and Bica, whose grandmotherly protection has followed me from Cluj-Napoca all the way to Stockholm;

to the women that have been my guidepost for everything that I do;

to my advisor, Kristina, for the patient guidance and endless wisdom;

and to Adi, without whom,

a heartfelt *mulțumesc*.

Abstract

This thesis explores how femicide is made visible and framed across Romanian online news media in a context of unprecedented public attention to gender-based violence. Focusing on a sample of 198 online news articles published in 2024 and 2025, the research applies a sequential mixed-methods design that combines quantitative content analysis with framing analysis of three high-profile femicide cases of 2025. Pulling from framing theory, feminist media scholarship, and intersectional theory, five dominant frames are outlined, revealing that increased semantic visibility of femicide has not produced increased structural and intersectional framing. Episodic framing, sensationalism, and stereotypical portrayals are still dominating representation, and structural factors stay largely overlooked, hindering the potential for reflexive awareness to develop among the public. These findings confirm and extend the visibility paradox identified in existing scholarship to an under-researched post-communist media context, contributing with an empirically grounded account of femicide framing at a historically significant moment in Romanian public discourse.

Keywords: femicide, gender-based violence, media framing, Romanian media, intersectionality

Table of contents

1. Introduction **6**
2. Research problem **10**
3. Background **12**
3.1. Femicide and domestic violence in Romania 12
3.2. The Romanian media landscape 17
3.3. Feminist activism and the visibility of femicide in Romania 21
4. Literature Review **23**
4.1. Media framing and news value 23
4.2. Gendered representations of violence 28
4.3. Intersectionality and media visibility 30
4.4. Media coverage of femicide 33
5. Method **36**
5.1. Ontological and epistemological foundations 36
5.2. Research design and mixed-methods approach 37
5.3. Data collection and sampling rationale 37
5.4. Quantitative Content Analysis 42
5.5. Framing Analysis 44
5.6. Ensuring research quality 48
6. Results and analysis **51**
6.1. Quantitative results and analysis 51
6.2. Qualitative results and analysis 67
7. Discussion **77**
7.1. Mapping femicide visibility 77
7.2. Framing femicide 78
7.3. Reflected ideologies 80
7.4. Importance of findings 82
7.5. Limitations 83
7.6. Future research 84
8. Conclusion **86**
References **87**
Appendices **93**

Abbreviations and acronyms

EIGE - European Institute for Gender Equality

EU - European Union

FRA - European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights

RESPECT (acronym) - **R**elationship skills strengthening, **E**mpowerment of women, **S**ervices ensured, **P**overty reduced, **E**nvironments made safe, **C**hild and adolescent abuse prevented, **T**ransformed attitudes, beliefs, and norms.

WHO - World Health Organization

UN - United Nations

UNODC - United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime

UN Women - United Nations Women

1. Introduction

At the beginning of 2024, the word *femicid*[1] was confined to feminist activist communication and the occasional fragmentary coverage of international policy progress. By the end of the following year, after three high-profile femicide cases pushed forward the need for legislative change, the press christened 2025 “the year of the femicides” (Popa, 2025), and persisting efforts of advocates and protesters seemed to have finally paid off. But gender-based violence has consistently remained a systemic problem that circles in and out of half-shadow in a media system that fails to build reflexive public awareness around this social issue.

According to the European Institute for Gender Equality, “49% of ever-partnered women in Romania have experienced psychological, physical (including threats), or sexual violence by an intimate partner in their lifetime” (Gender Equality Index, 2024) and in 2022 alone, there were 67 victims of femicide recorded by the police, which is more than a woman being killed every week in Romania. Femicide, defined by EIGE as "killing of women and girls because of their gender" (Gender Equality Index, 2024), is the most extreme form of gender-based violence, yet only towards the end of April 2026 a bill defining femicide as a crime was finally promulgated by the country’s president, Nicușor Dan (Coșlea, 2026). This delayed institutional reaction has a ripple effect on how femicides are reported in Romania, and how Romanian citizens perceive femicides and acts of domestic violence in general.

Despite femicide being generally understood as the killing of women because they are women, it has a political nature, women’s deaths being “a result of what is political” (Kayir & Kalav, 2016). While definitions vary across legal and academic contexts, the term is most commonly used to describe gender-related killings, particularly those occurring in the context of domestic and intimate partner violence.

Research on the media representation of femicide has consistently shown that news coverage occupies a crucial role in shaping public understanding of violence against women. Existing scholarship highlights that femicide is frequently framed through episodic, individualized narratives that emphasize personal relationships, emotional drama, or deviant behavior rather

[1] Romanian for *femicide*

than structural conditions, such as gender inequality, systemic failures, and social norms. Bouzerdan and Whitten-Woodring (2018) demonstrate that news coverage of femicide often isolates incidents from broader patterns of human rights violation, which limits the potential of femicide to be perceived as systemic. Similarly, Aldrete and Fernández-Ardèvol (2023) identify a paradox within femicide reporting, namely that despite the visibility, emphasis on femicide does not translate to structural framing, and episodic frames remain dominant even in contexts where femicide had become a recognized public issue. Together, these studies point to a persistent gap between increased visibility and meaningful reframing, a tension that remains underexplored in many national contexts.

Within Romania and the broader Eastern European and Balkan region, where femicide is an acute problem, scholarly attention to mediated femicide remains comparatively limited, though a growing body of research has begun to address this gap. Studies focusing on Romania highlight persistent patterns of sensationalism, victim-blaming, and the individualized framing of violence against women, as well as the marginalization of cases involving women from lower socio-economic backgrounds, rural areas, or ethnic minorities (Balica, 2021; Balica, Marinescu & Balica, 2020; Rovența-Frumușani & Stoica, 2023). In the same vein, regional scholarship emphasizes how gender-based violence is often depoliticized or moralized in media narratives, limiting its recognition as a structural social problem (Papa, Kourous & Lambe, 2025).

In this context, the particular quality of this thesis is the topicality and actuality of femicide visibility in Romania, as the semantic and conceptual adoption of femicide is a recent development that has not been scholarly examined yet. At what can be assumed to be the precipice of meaningful change, it is important to explore how this new concept is built into embedded news frames, how it is made sense of as it gains visibility, and how its framing constructs public awareness of femicide.

This thesis is informed by intersectional feminist theory, which emphasizes how gender-based violence is unevenly experienced and represented across lines of class, ethnicity, age, and social status (Collins & Bilge, 2020; Hall, 2017; Ahmed, 2007). Intersectionality provides a critical lens for examining not only whose stories become visible, but how respectability and social value shape media attention. By integrating framing theory with intersectional analysis, this

research situates femicide reporting within broader structures of power, inequality, and media production.

The thesis is structured as follows. A Research Problem chapter sets the aim and research questions of the thesis. Then, an extensive three-part Background chapter offers details of the Romanian context. The Literature Review chapter covers framing theories and news values, gendered representations of violence, intersectionality within media visibility, and media coverage of femicide. The Method chapter traces the ontological and epistemological foundations, the research design, material, and methodological set-up of both stages of analysis, ending with a transparent account of research quality. The results are presented and analyzed in the Results and analysis chapter. The Discussion chapter seeks to answer the two research questions. Lastly, the thesis ends with a Conclusion.

2. Research problem

This thesis aims to examine how femicide is covered across Romania's media system in the context of recently increased public attention to gender-based violence. The empirical focus will be online news reporting on national femicide cases published by Romanian news outlets. The analysis will adopt a mixed-methods approach combining quantitative content analysis with framing analysis, in order to capture both broader patterns of visibility and the meanings constructed within individual high-profile cases. Analytical dimensions such as visibility, frame dominance, responsibility attribution, and the inclusion or exclusion of structural and intersectional explanations of gender-based violence will be included.

The study addresses a central tension in feminist media scholarship, namely the often conflicting dynamic between heightened visibility of gender-based violence, its structural interpretations, and news framing impact on public awareness. Against this background, Romania represents an under-researched case within European and global media studies, especially concerning femicide and gender-based violence. As a post-communist media system characterized by commercial pressures and a tradition of deprofessionalized journalism, Romania offers a valuable context to examine how a boost in public attention interacts with embedded journalistic framing practices. By focusing on news coverage of femicide, this thesis aims to contribute to broader discussions of how news mediate gender-based violence and whether increased visibility corresponds to shifts towards more structural and intersectional understandings.

The research questions guiding this thesis are:

- RQ1: How are femicide cases made visible and framed across Romanian online news media?
- RQ2: How does Romanian news coverage of femicide frame the public understanding of femicide as a social issue?

A sequential mixed-methods research design will be employed to answer the research questions, by combining quantitative content analysis and framing analysis. This approach is expected to produce distinct, yet complementary insights: the deductive quantitative stage will provide

breadth through mapping, while the inductive qualitative stage will offer depth through interpretation.

3. Background

Before diving into the Literature Review, this Background chapter serves as a three-part induction into femicide in Romania, the particularities of the Romanian media system, and recent feminist activism and femicide visibility trends.

3.1. Femicide and domestic violence in Romania

3.1.1. Gender-based violence in Europe and Romania

Between 2020 and 2024, Eurostat collected data for a comprehensive report on gender-based violence in the European Union. Among their key findings, the results of a Wave 2021 survey are most striking: “Around one third of women in the EU have experienced physical or sexual violence in adulthood” (Eurostat, 2024). Data amassed by UN Women strengthens this conclusion by bringing it to global scale, with an estimated 840 million women having been subjected to violence (physical and/or sexual intimate partner, non-partner, or both) at least once in their life at global level, not including sexual harassment. More so concerning is the fact that this recent data indicates very slow progress from previous years: only 0.2% annual decline over the last two decades (UN Women, 2025). Not unexpectedly, in the absence of homogeneously implemented legislation, gender-based violence remains widespread.

Turning to the EU Gender-Based Violence Survey: Evidence for Policy and Practice report put together by FRA and EIGE, domestic violence was found to still be largely committed by men, with 82.5% of cases within the EU being attributed to men and between 73.8% and 97.9% to male perpetrators in each EU member state individually (EU Gender-based Violence Survey, 2026). There is also a notable reporting gap, as only 13.9% of physical and/or sexual violence victims contacted the police and 20.5% connected with social or health services, while instances of intimate partner violence were found to be reported far less (EU Gender-based Violence Survey, 2026). As a consequence, gender-based violence persists as a globally pervasive issue.

While international agencies convened to instill frameworks to prevent gender-based violence against women—one such notable project being the RESPECT (women) framework, developed under the leadership of WHO and UN Women—the practical counterparts of these theoretical

efforts are still fragmented. In fact, as Guaita-Fernández et. al point out, the European Union faces a particularly intricate obstacle in implementing foundational guidelines that combat gender-based violence: despite legislative proposals for prevention, there is still a lack of specific legal instruments. Globally, this "lack of international connection in an area where unity is required highlights the need for harmonised normative regulation, which favours gender equality and reduces gender-based violence-domestic violence" (Guaita-Fernández et al., 2023, p. 2).

Looking at where Romania is placed on the map in this context, one finds that its rates are particularly high in comparison with other EU member states. According to EIGE's 100-point scale Gender Equality Index (2025), Romania's score for violence against women is 36.5 points, which is higher than the EU average, with higher rates than average for prevalence (26.5), severity (48.1), and disclosure (34.8). Additionally, data shows that 42% of women in Romania have experienced physical and/or sexual violence since the age of 15 (Gender Equality Index, 2025).

Consistent with global trends, an alarming number of cases in Romania remain unreported. EIGE's report shows that approximately 34% of women who have experienced physical and sexual violence by any perpetrator (not just intimate partner violence) in the past 12 months (at the time of the data collection) have not only not reported their experience to health or social services, but have not told anyone altogether (Gender Equality Index, 2025). As expected, the consequences extend beyond immediate violence: according to EIGE, a disquieting 69% of women were left with health issues after instances of physical and/or sexual violence.

Turning back to global and European statistics, Romania peaks out as a country where gender-based violence and domestic violence are notably ubiquitous concerns that bleed through the cracks of everyday life and more often than not, persist in falling under the radar, cases remaining under-reported or treated as individual crimes rather than manifestations of systemic violence. Understanding this broader context is essential for examining how extreme manifestations of gender-based violence, such as femicide, are perceived and represented in public discourse.

3.1.2. Conceptualizing gender-based violence and femicide

Within the gender-based violence discourse, the concept of femicide has emerged as a key analytical term employed when describing the killing of women because of their gender. While definitions vary across academic and policy contexts, scholars largely agree that femicide refers to gender-related killings rooted in structural inequalities and misogyny. Radford provides such a definition of femicide as "the misogynistic killing of women by men" (Radford & Russell, 1992 cited in Rodat, 2022, p. 73), while Russell underlines the understanding of femicide as "the killing of women by men because they are women" (Russell & Harmes, 2001 cited in Rodat, 2022, p. 73). Rodat further emphasizes the different nuances that might be prioritized in certain definitions depending on context, such as focus on the male gender of the perpetrators, the female gender of the victims, the misogynistic motivations of the perpetrator, or the intentional targeting of women or girls (Rodat, 2022, p.73).

Closely linked to broader forms of gender-based violence, femicide is often confused for domestic violence and intimate partner violence. However, according to the definitions provided by Rodat (2022) while domestic violence refers to violence occurring in domestic settings, such as marriage or cohabitation, and comprises forms of abuse of physical, psychological, sexual, social, or economic nature aimed at another family member, intimate partner violence specifically refers to the harmful behaviors committed by current or former partners within an intimate relationship. In this context, the concept of intimate partner femicide refers to the killing of a woman by a current or former partner (spouse, boyfriend, or cohabiting partner). Research shows that this form of femicide represents one of the most common manifestations of femicide globally: according to UNODC Research, among the women murdered by intimate partners or other family members in Europe in 2024, 64% were victims of intimate partners (UNODC & UN Women, 2025, p.4).

Looking back to international efforts, global and regional institutions have begun recognizing femicide as a distinct manifestation of gender-based violence. The definition widely referenced in European policy discussions originates from the UN' 2012 Vienna Declaration on Femicide, which describes the term as:

> Killing of women and girls because of their gender, which can take the form of, inter alia: (1) the murder of women as a result of intimate partner violence; (2) the torture and misogynist slaying of women; (3) killing of women and girls in the name of "honour"; (4) targeted killing of women and girls in the context of armed conflict; (5) dowry-related

> killings of women; (6) killing of women and girls because of their sexual orientation and gender identity; (7) the killing of aboriginal and indigenous women and girls because of their gender; (8) female infanticide and gender-based sex selection foeticide; (9) genital mutilation related deaths; (10) accusations of witchcraft; and (11) other femicides connected with gangs, organized crime, drug dealers, human trafficking and the proliferation of small arms. (United Nations, 2013, p.2)

This definition will be used as a guidepost in this thesis, alongside EIGE's statistical definition from their 2017 glossary, which reads as follows:

> The killing of a woman by an intimate partner and the death of a woman as a result of a practice that is harmful to women. Intimate partner is understood as a former or current spouse or partner, whether or not the perpetrator shares or has shared the same residence with the victim. (Gender Equality Index, 2017)

While the Vienna declaration definition provides more nuance that fits the purpose of the qualitative framing analysis better, this statistical definition was chosen to inform the quantitative step of this thesis as it is used in EU reports on femicide and gender-based violence. In the absence of a legal definition of femicide in Romania, these European definitions are found to be the most appropriate fit. It is, however, worth mentioning that EIGE admits its own limitations in providing an updated glossary.

Among other international efforts in combating femicide and gender-based violence, the Istanbul Convention is the most comprehensive international human rights treaty on preventing and combatting violence against women and domestic violence (Gender Equality Index, 2025). Romania signed this treaty in June 2014, ratified it in May 2016, and began implementation in September 2016—which makes 2026 the year the Convention turns a decade since entering Romania full force.

3.1.3. Femicide and media visibility in Romania

As previously established, while gender-based violence represents a widespread issue on a global level, EU data regarding the Romanian context reveals consistently patterns of particular concern when it comes to domestic violence and intimate partner killings. EIGE's statistical data indicating high prevalence rates of violence against women alongside significant reporting gaps unveil arduous dynamics that only impede the process of identifying and documenting femicide cases on a national level. Often subsumed under broader homicide statistics or framed as isolated criminal incidents, femicide cases are rarely seen as manifestations of systemic gender-based

violence. As a result, public understanding of femicide is frequently shaped by media coverage of individual cases more than by institutional data or legal frameworks.

The media, then, plays a central role in shaping public perceptions of violence, not just by reporting events, but by determining which cases become visible and how they are framed in public discourse as well. In her research on the commodification of homicide in Romania, Badea (2025) turns to Wong and Harraway (2020) to interweave the concepts of newsworthiness based on sensationalism and the rarity theory, which explains how particularly unusual murders receive attention based on their potential to fulfill the demand for emotional impact (Wong & Harraway, 2020 cited in Badea, 2025, p. 113). Within this logic, some cases involving women might attract heightened attention as individual instances of crime due to their shocking or atypical nature.

In the Romanian media landscape, this dynamic has been observed in the coverage of femicide cases, where violence is often transformed into marketable news products, as Badea points out. According to her, such reporting practices contribute to the "commodification of homicide": acts of violence packaged as sensational narratives that generate audience engagement and commercial value, a "double commodification of suffering and fear" (Badea, 2025, p. 125).

This process can also reinforce problematic representational patterns, including victim-blaming and the construction of an "ideal victim" (Gekoski et al., 2012 cited in Badea, 2025, p. 120). Meanwhile, the cases that center women from marginalized communities—such as lower class, rural, or Roma women in Romania—are prone to receiving less visibility or a framing that implicitly attributes responsibility to the victims instead of the perpetrators. Similarly, if the victims are involved in sex work or homelessness, they might be "stereotyped as complicit in their own victimization" (Lundman, 2003 cited in Badea, 2025, p. 113).

Another recurring issue in Romania media coverage is the tendency to treat femicide as an isolated tragedy rather than situating it within a broader systemic pattern of domestic abuse. As Badea underlines, this limitation on the media's part nurtures a culture of harmful journalistic practices and feeds into the failure to draw connections between recognizing systemic patterns and emphasizing protective measures (Badea, 2025, p. 115). As a consequence, the structural dimensions of gender-based violence often remain obscured, impeding the potential for public recognition of femicide as part of an innate social problem.

Understanding how femicide cases become visible in media narratives is essential for examining the broader relationship between violence against women, public discourse, and media representation in Romania. To better grasp how such narratives are produced and circulated, it is necessary to consider the broader structural characteristics of the Romanian media system in which these representations emerge.

3.2. The Romanian media landscape

3.2.1. Historical origins

In order to understand Romania's media system today, one has to consider its development through a post-communist transformation pipeline. As expected, the fall of communism after the revolution of 1989 left an uncontested mark on Romanian society, from politics and economy to culture and social life. Focusing specifically on the media sector, what followed after the collapse of the communist regime was a rapid liberalization of media institutions. However, the transition towards democratic media structures occurred under particularly weak conditions from a structural point of view. Decades later, scholars such as Botan (2024) can easily point to what was likely perceived as abrupt then: this transition, unlike other Eastern European countries', was marked by "divergent political and social trajectories, attributed in part to the absence of liberal elites and a robust civil society" (Botan, 2024, p. 2). In other words, at the precipice of democratization, the Romanian media landscape found itself characterized by high levels of political influence, very limited press freedom, and an even weaker public service broadcasting sector.

Building on broader discussions about the relationship between media and political power, Popa (2011) explores the structural constraints shaping Romanian journalism after transitioning to democracy. While democratic theory commonly assigns the media a watchdog role and positions journalists as gatekeepers of public information (McQuail, 2007 cited in Popa, 2011), Popa argues that Romanian journalism has historically operated under significant political influence. As democratization coincided with the fast-paced development of new means of communication, Romania struggled to keep up without falling under economic and political pressures. This prompted Petcu's (2000) observation that the authentic journalist can hardly be met in Romania, due to a lack of professional culture and of an "ideology of information property"—which are

usually found in states that have a democratic tradition (Petcu, 2000 cited in Popa, 2011, p. 130). As Popa concludes, “the public is more or less aware of the fact that the Romanian mass-media has been experiencing a political control” (Popa, 2011, p. 132).

Like many scholars before, Botan attempted to make sense of the Romanian media system using Hallin and Mancini’s (2004) models of Western media systems—based on advanced democracies that shared similar political systems and histories—and Humprecht et al.’s (2022) emphasized limitations of this model in capturing the post-communist particularities experienced in Eastern Europe. In fact, Humprecht et al. contributed to a new three-cluster model that considers digitalization, hybridization of media environments, and political and economic pressures specific to post-communist countries (Botan, 2024).

Interestingly, Romanian media distinguishes itself even within the Eastern European backdrop, where Western shareholders were key actors in the media system’s evolution by financing emerging private television stations. In Romania, foreign investments in media were few and temporary, privatization occurring largely through domestic actors (Botan, 2024). As a result, the emerging media market was an entanglement of decreased institutionalization and increased political influences.

Taken together, the literature suggests a broad scholarly consensus that the Romanian media system has developed under persistent political and economic pressures that continue to shape journalistic practices today. While these studies offer valuable insights into the structural characteristics of the Romanian media system, they also highlight the need for further research examining how these dynamics manifest in specific areas of news coverage.

3.2.2. Media capture

In the 1990s and 2000s, the privatization of Romanian media created new power structures within the industry. According to Coman (2003), this privatization was two-fold: the spontaneous privatization right after the 1989 revolution, when journalists seized the press institutions, and the state-mediated privatization that enabled in many cases fraudulent practices. This set the foundations of what Coman coined the “new media bourgeoisie”—so-called “star journalists” occupying managerial and ownership roles within media organizations, and prioritizing content meant to feed into their individual visibility (Coman, 2004 cited in Marincea, 2023, p. 88).

In time, many of the major Romanian media organizations came under the ownership of businessmen with strong political and economic agendas. As Marincea highlights, many of these businessmen were investigated for corruption, with some even being criminally charged or imprisoned (Marincea, 2023, p. 91). Naturally, media organizations were used increasingly as instruments in the advancement of various political and economic interests, which translated to poor editorial practices, shaped by commercial pressures, political influences, and the personal networks of media owners.

It has long been known that television occupies an important place in the general Romanian public's life and homes, yet the tabloidization and depoliticization of television news was only the blueprint for what shortly applied to the newspaper market as well. As media organizations became tools for political and economic agendas, editorial priorities and coverage logic were compromised, and sensationalism was drawn to the heart of Romanian news. The logic of news production shifted when tabloidization first became a definitory characteristic of Romanian television, and then only extended itself to the newspaper market and, later on, to online media.

This transformation contributed to the declining quality of media content and the erosion of journalistic integrity. With journalists themselves becoming vulnerable to political and commercial pressures, Romania became one of the highest risk countries to media pluralism within the European Union, while also being among the countries with the poorest quality of media content (Marincea, 2023, p. 89).

These structural dynamics are not only relevant at the level of media ownership and institutional organization but also influence everyday journalistic routines and editorial priorities.

3.2.3. Professionalization crisis

In democratic societies, codes of ethics and professional norms are essential to safeguarding journalistic integrity; however, in post-revolution Romania, legal measures intended to protect media freedom and editorial independence failed to be applied practically. As a consequence, scholars such as Petcu believed "the authentic journalist can hardly be met in Romania" (Petcu, 2000 cited in Popa, 2011, p. 130) due to the absence of a strong professional culture and the lack of an understanding of information property common in well-defined democratic systems. Botan

later also highlighted how media freedom remained largely fragile as political influence expanded and journalistic autonomy weakened (Botan, 2024, p. 11).

These precarious conditions only increased journalists' vulnerability to political and economical pressures, which accelerated the deprofessionalization of the field. This was particularly prevalent after the financial crisis of 2008, when political manipulation thrived in the form of disinformation. This erosion of professional norms contributed to the deprofessionalization of Romanian journalism. Under these conditions, journalistic practices such as sensationalism, victim-blaming, or episodic framing have persisted in the last decades—they are structural conditions that have implications for how social issues are reported on in Romanian news, including, if not especially, issues such as gender-based violence and femicide.

Such structural conditions are particularly relevant when examining how sensitive social issues are reported in the news, as professional norms and editorial independence play a central role in shaping journalistic framing. While these structural challenges have shaped Romanian journalism for decades, more recent transformations have also been driven by the rapid digitalization of the media environment.

3.2.4. Digitalization and trust crisis

In the last two decades, Romania's media landscape, following global trends in the industry, has been significantly shaped by digitalization. Online platforms and social networks have become key channels for news dissemination, with digital media representing 35% of the Romanian media market by 2022 (Botan, 2024, p. 7) and Romanians increasingly consuming news through online media and social media platforms, mirroring broader global media consumption trends.

Despite the growth of digital news consumption, trust in journalism remained low. In fact, the Reuters Institute Digital News Report of 2023 found "significant skepticism towards media organizations and journalists in Romania, with overall trust in media hitting a record low of 32%" (Botan, 2024, p. 10), one of the lowest levels in Europe (compared to Sweden's score of 50%). Factors such as propaganda funding of main newsrooms, and smear campaigns against investigative journalists have led to this apprehension, despite a high level of saturation with sensationalism—which, as a positive reaction, resulted in these small investigative newsrooms.

As argued by Safiya Noble in *Algorithms of Oppression* (2018), algorithms increasingly prioritize content that is sensational, emotionally triggering, and generally speaking engaging. Search engines and digital platforms can reinforce harmful social hierarchies by amplifying certain types of content. In this context, sensationalized or misogynistic narratives may receive greater algorithmic amplification, shaping how gender-related issues circulate in digital media environments.

These structural characteristics of the Romanian media system are important for understanding how social issues are represented in the press. Elements such as the high levels of political influence and commercial pressures, or the weak institutional safeguards for journalistic independence are embedded at this point in reporting practices and within the very framework editorial priorities are shaped after. In this context, examining how femicide cases are made visible and framed in Romanian online news media provides insight into how these broader structural conditions within the media system leave their mark on journalistic representations of gender-based violence.

3.3. Feminist activism and the visibility of femicide in Romania

Within this media system, in recent years, feminist activism in Romania has played a vital role in bringing gender-based violence and femicide into the orbit of public debates. Civil society organizations and grassroots initiatives have worked to document cases, offer financial and medical support to victims, bridge the relationship between victims and local authorities or legal representatives, and raise awareness about existing patterns of systemic violence against women. These efforts have been particularly significant in a media environment characterized by treating femicide cases as isolated incidents rather than consequences of structural gender inequality.

The pervasiveness of digital communication has facilitated local and national organizations' efforts to raise awareness. One of the most visible digital initiatives addressing femicide in Romania has been the Instagram page Stop Femicidelor—a grassroots effort aimed at documenting and publicizing cases of femicide, as well as reporting on instances of domestic violence invisible in the media. Presenting information about these cases in a clear, unbiased, discoursively homogenous format, the page has begun publishing each femicide case since January 2025 under a simple, yet impactful visual slide stating the number of the case. In January

2026, it was concluded that the year 2025 had bore witness to 66 cases of femicide. Through consistent documentation and online dissemination, the initiative has contributed to increasing public awareness of femicide as a systemic issue rather than a series of unrelated crimes, with newsrooms picking up on the phenomenon and calling 2025 “the year of the femicides” (Popa, 2025).

Additionally, Romanian nonprofits have also played a key role in advocating for stronger institutional responses to violence against women. Organizations such as Asociația Anais and Centrul Filia have worked to provide support services for victims of domestic violence, conduct awareness campaigns, lobby for legislative reforms, facilitate protests, petitions, and fundraisers, and disseminate educational materials about gender-based violence and domestic violence, among many other important feminist topics. In recent years, these organizations have progressively collaborated with activists, journalists, and public figures alike to amplify discussions about femicide and gender-based violence in public discourse.

As a result, growing public attention to femicide has also contributed to renewed political discussions about the legal recognition of gender-based killings in Romania. In 2025, this issue was brought back into discussion in light of heightened coverage of the high-profile femicide cases explored in this thesis, and the lack of a legal definition of femicide in Romania’s Criminal Code was exposed. Policymakers have since debated legislative initiatives aimed at strengthening protections against violence targeting women and recognizing femicide as a distinct legal category. As of April 2026, Romania’s president has promulgated this bill that, besides offering a clear legal definition of femicide, includes mandatory annual data on femicide and related acts of violence, aggravated penalties, and special protections for children orphaned by femicide (Marica, 2026).

This progress due to activist efforts demonstrates how femicide has gradually entered Romanian public discourse, showcasing the essential role that media visibility and digital communication play in shaping how gender-based violence is recognized and discussed.

4. Literature Review

4.1. Media framing and news value

In order to understand how media representations shape public perceptions of social issues, it is only natural to turn to framing theory as a foundational concept. According to Entman (1993), framing "consistently offers a way to describe the power of a communicating text" (Entman, 1993, p. 51). In other words, framing refers to the process through which texts select and prioritize certain aspects of reality by making them more salient, and in doing so, bringing to the forefront particular definitions, interpretations, causes of societal problems, moral evaluations, and potential solutions (Entman, 1993, p. 52). As such, frames do more than simply reflecting reality as it is: they actively construct it by placing elements in a hierarchy of visibility, where certain aspects of reality are underlined, while others are downplayed or even omitted altogether.

In order to conceptualize frames and how they "diagnose, evaluate, and prescribe" (Entman, 1993, p. 52), Entman explains the concepts of selection and salience. Sometimes intentionally and other times not, communicators—in many cases including that of this research, they are journalists in newsrooms—make framing decisions guided by interpretive schemas embedded within their professional and organizational environments. These schemas shape what is deemed relevant, how events are narrated, and which perspectives dominate (Entman, 1993, p. 52). This projects onto how much the framing generated in media happens as a conscious effort on the journalist's part, and how much of it mirrors the belief system ingrafted in the newsroom, where the journalist is trained and formed professionally.

In fact, the notion of journalistic objectivity in and of itself is questioned by Entman, who unveils that the very rules journalists perceive as guarantors of neutrality contain biases that nurture dominant frames. However, professional education—or the lack thereof—renders a palpable difference between unprepared, easily manipulated journalists and those who are "better equipped to construct news that makes equally salient (...) two or more interpretations of problems" (Entman, 1993, p. 57).

Salience can be achieved by placement, repetition, or cultural association of certain pieces of information, but heightened prominence does not necessarily translate to real influence of audience thinking (Entman, 1993, p. 53). It is equally important to keep in mind, as Entman highlights, that frames carry by definition omissions of bits of information too, not just inclusion or underlinings of certain details (Entman, 1993, p. 54). This means that frames have the power to illuminate or obscure particular elements of reality, and, as such, compell audiences to react in a specific manner, all while "reflecting the play of power and boundaries of discourse over an issue" (Entman, 1993, p. 55). This perspective is particularly relevant when examining how complex social problems such as femicide are reduced, individualized, or conversely contextualized in media discourse.

Building on this, Entman (2004) develops the relationship between framing and power through the concept of cascading activation, that he explains through the stratified manner in which frames are spread and promoted: while some actors have little control over which elements become visible or even dominant to the public through news, others have much more power to control which and how frames are promoted (Entman, 2004, p. 9). The cascade model "builds on and supplements previous approaches" (Entman, 2004, p. 12): hierarchy and variations are taken into account and public opinion, while at the very bottom of the cascade, is kept in mind by those in power throughout the process—the public's reactions are anticipated and dictate what those in power express (Entman, 2004, p. 13).

Repetition plays a crucial role in this dynamic, as recurring frames reinforce cognitive associations and normalize particular interpretations over time (Entman, 2004, p. 15). What the cascade model suggests is that beyond simply receiving "ill-digested and scattered morsels" (Entman, 2004, p. 17) from the media, the public needs a counterframe made of "culturally resonant words and images, one that attains sufficient magnitude to gain wide understanding as a sensible alternative" (Entman, 2004, p. 17).

While Entman's framework explains how frames operate and circulate, Iyengar (1994) provides a particularly useful typology for analyzing media representations of social issues. Although Iyengar turned to television news in order to construe how political issues are framed, the same rationale can now be applied to online news: political issues—category in which violence and

femicide both belong—are framed as either episodic or thematic (Iyengar, 1994, p. 13). While episodic frames portray the object of reporting as an isolated incident, thematic frames contextualize public issues, correlating them with similar outcomes or general conditions. It is, however, important to note that Iyengar very clearly spells out the fact that news reports are rarely purely thematic or episodic; but one always dominates (Iyengar, 1994:14).

But before even detailing how episodic and thematic frames occur, Iyengar carves out the importance of responsibility. He differentiates between two types of responsibilities for national issues: causal responsibility, which is centered around the origin of the problem, and treatment responsibility, which is focused on the entity that holds the power to terminate—or at least temporarily pause—the problem (Iyengar, 1994, p. 8). With demonstrated impact of causal and treatment responsibility attribution on public perception of national issues (Iyengar, 1994, p. 9), it is only sensible to consider what a nation makes of issues such as femicide and who is deemed responsible.

Decades later, assessing political campaign material produced by both political actors and news media, Hänggli (2012) investigates the dynamics of frame building in news media, and, building upon existing framing theories, distinguishes between frame presence and frame frequency. While the aforementioned succeed at conceptualizing framing and identifying the main typologies of frames, her research delves into the mechanisms used by political actors to strategically build frames and promote them in the context of media attention. This once again reinforces the idea that those who uphold more institutional authority are ultimately better positioned to shape public discourse through the media and influence how issues are represented.

If Hänggli stratifies one's understanding of frames by distinguishing the factors affecting frame presence and frequency in news coverage, Bartholomé et al. (2017) contribute to the existing body of literature on framing by unveiling the different types of conflict frames and the role of aspects such as context in frame-building. Their work, while centered around political news coverage, underscores the differences in frames both content wise and in the varying degrees to which journalists actively shape or merely relay competing perspectives. This adds a significant layer of complexity to framing analysis, suggesting that media representations cannot and should not be reduced to a single dominant logic.

However, it is not only that frames are built in news reporting; there are also news values that guide how newsrooms prioritize the content that they eventually inflict dominant frames upon. Turning to Harcup and O'Neill's (2017) revisitation of Galtung and Ruge's 1965 taxonomy of news values, an updated set of contemporary news values containing criteria such as exclusivity, conflict, shareability, and celebrity guide editorial decisions and shape the selection of events that become newsworthy.

In the context of digital media, these dynamics have evolved further, with scholars like Ittefaq (2018) emphasizing the role of audience engagement and platform logics in shaping news values. Preeminent arguments center around sensationalism and profit: within this globalized digital market, newsrooms prioritize sensationalism in their pursuit of ad revenue—this means that social media platforms fulfil the role of "indicators of newsworthiness" (Ittefaq, 2018, p. 95). In this context, the impact is two-fold: on the one hand, ragebait content and clickbait headlines can enable audiences to engage with news articles published online; yet, on the other hand, if a case such as the anti-femicide Instagram page Stop Femicidelor gains traction, it can force its way into the professional news value index.

Ittefaq offers a multi-actor nuance to news value, consisting of internal and external factors: the former being reporters or editors who develop a sense of news value based on organizational policy, while the latter playing a proactive role as the audience itself and shaping frames indirectly by engaging with sensationalist content and signaling to media outlets what represents a profitable reporting avenue (Ittefaq, 2018, p. 87).

Finally, the relationship between media, crime, and representation further contextualizes these dynamics. Adopting a social constructionist perspective, Surette explains how coverage is also heavily influenced by claims makers, "the promoters, activists, experts, spokespersons, and sometimes celebrities involved in forwarding specific claims about a social condition" (Surette, 2007, p. 34). From this perspective, specific constructions of reality become socially accepted when certain claims makers win in their competition with others, pushing their own view of reality until it dominates its alternatives. (Surette, 2007, p. 34). Following this logic, news coverage of femicide cannot be neutral as long as it remains the product of the tension between mainstream sensationalist reporting and pressures from organizations and activists.

Media representations frequently rely on the ideal victim trope, portraying victims as “the innocent, naive, trusting, obviously–in-need-of-protection true human” (Surette, 2007, p. 185)—which goes hand in hand with the pre-established social roles of narratives. Applying them to gender, these narratives often reinforce stereotypes of female vulnerability and male predatoriness. Looking at trends in entertainment, Surette observes how female victimization is portrayed in the media through “fewer female villains, more female assistant heroes, and many more female victims” (Surette, 2007, p. 57). The focus is often on visually engaging and sensational stories, which position female offenders and victims alike as “violent and deserving of punishment” (Surette, 2007, p. 54) or “weak, defenseless—and often stupid—victim sheep” (Surette, 2007, p. 184), prioritizing spectacle over structural realities of gender-based violence.

Surette also covers memorial criminal justice policies, as the link between media and criminal justice policy—high-profile cases sometimes have a tangible impact by exposing gaps in the law system and mobilizing the public to push for policies that fill those gaps, the cases “being co-opted as symbols for specific policy campaigns” (Surette, 2007, p. 2). In fact, this is what happened in Romania since June 2025: following the intense coverage of the Teodora Marcu case, femicide was identified as missing from the country’s legal code, which pushed initially activists and nonprofits, then ultimately the general public to demand legal changes. As a result, in early 2026 the Romanian Senate backed the femicide bill, after which in March of the same year the Parliament adopted it, the last step left being promulgation by the president.

Taken together, these theoretical perspectives form a framework for analyzing how media both selects and represents issues such as femicide. Framing theory shows how meaning is constructed, news value theory clarifies why certain cases become visible while others are kept in anonymity, and crime media scholarship highlights the narrative patterns through which violence is portrayed. The intersection of these dynamics brings about a central question for this research: whether increased visibility of femicide in Romanian media can be attributed to a shift from episodic, individualized narratives towards more structural and intersectional forms of representation.

4.2. Gendered representations of violence

While framing theory explains how media constructs meaning, feminist media scholarship underscores how these constructions are inherently gendered. Representations of violence are not neutral reflections of reality, they are, instead, shaped by deeply embedded cultural narratives that structure how gender, power, and victimhood are perceived.

A foundational contribution to this perspective is offered by Teresa de Lauretis in *The violence of representation* (1989), who posits that "violence is en-gendered in representation" (de Lauretis, 1989, p. 240)—for her, representation itself can constitute a form of violence by positioning subjects within uneven systems of meaning. More than a descriptive category, gender is a social and cultural construct with "concrete existence in cultural forms and actual weight in social relations" that make it "a political issue that cannot be evaded or wished away, much as one would want to, be one male or female" (de Lauretis, 1989, p. 245). In other words, the ways in which violence is narrated, visualized, and circulated in the media are inherently political.

Moreover, critical of Foucault, de Lauretis posits that despite his radical politics and influence over the collective understanding of how power and social relations intersect and interact, Foucault's blind spot is represented by "the techniques and discursive strategies by which gender is constructed and violence is en-gendered" (de Lauretis, 1989, p. 245). This shifts the focus from violence as an event to violence as a representational practice.

What de Lauretis builds the foundations of is the argument that reporting choices such as sensationalism, beneath commercial interests and entrenched newsroom habits, are rooted in linguistic and rhetorical violence. Referencing Breines and Gordon (1983), she highlights that "violence is a sign of *a power struggle for the maintenance of a certain kind of social order*" (Breines & Gordon, 1983 cited in de Lauretis, 1989 p. 242). From this perspective, journalistic choices such as sensationalist language or selective details can reproduce forms of symbolic violence by reinforcing unequal gendered positions.

Similarly, adding to this theoretical foundation, Cuklanz (2013) envisions mainstream media as an ideological site where meanings of gendered violence are perpetually produced and reproduced. Long-term changes into how mainstream news and entertainment represent domestic

violence and sexual abuse: her argument is that despite global shifts towards increased visibility (as opposed to previous silence), the visibility is more often than not selective.

Note-worthy media patterns identified by Cuklanz include ideological persistence, discursive limits, and genre influence. Ideologically speaking, she emphasizes that the media often replicates certain myths when reporting on intimate partner violence. Moreover, the fact that perpetrators tend to be individualized rather than seen as products of systemic patriarchy further proves that while legal definitions of violence are introduced, debated, and improved along time, these seemingly positive changes still fail to translate into significant shifts in media framing. Cuklanz equally suggests that different media genres contribute to a mutual reinforcement of a common sense understanding of what violence looks like: objectified female characters, for example, encourage the public to "think of women and girls as less than human" (Cuklanz, 2013, p. 32).

The normalization of gendered violence is further examined by Rolle et al. (2020). They also recognize how the dramatic, sensationalist language used in news coverage can shape public perception, push specific agendas, or strengthen deeply rooted ideas (Rolle et al., 2020, p. 180). Their research highlights how new media representations of domestic violence victims and offenders legitimize violence against women through the erasure of consent, blurring the boundaries between acceptable and unacceptable behaviors and contributing to the implanting of violence within everyday cultural practices. In this context, violence is frequently aestheticized, often framed as passionate or transgressive, masking its coercive nature.

Because reporting is predominantly episodic and cases of emotional, psychological, and verbal abuse are frequently minimized or ignored (Rolle et al., 2020, p. 185), systemic objectification remains the foundation, placing gendered violence as inevitable or even natural. Concurrently, while female victims' voices are eroded, male perpetrators receive sympathetic descriptions that only contribute to the minimization of their violence (Rolle et al., 2020, p. 191), contrasting with female perpetrators' portrayal as deviant and inherently bad (Rolle et al., 2020, p. 192). As a consequence, there is a certain cultural habit that is being built of assigning rationality and agency to women only when the context requires them to be responsible for a violent situation.

Victims are, then, denied subjectivity, their experiences being reframed through external interpretations that diminish their capacity to define their own realities.

Considering all of these perspectives, they showcase that media representations of violence against women are shaped by enduring gendered logics that extend beyond individual cases. Violence is framed through journalistic practices and, at the same time, it is ingrained in broader cultural narratives that normalize, individualize, and depoliticize it. This has crucial implications in the study of femicide, proposing that increased visibility does not automatically challenge dominant representations, but rather that media can maintain the reproduction of patterns that conceal structural inequalities and limit the recognition of gender-based violence as a systemic issue. In this context, understanding how violence is framed equally requires examining how gender structures these representations.

4.3. Intersectionality and media visibility

At its origins, intersectionality has been conceptualized by Kimberlé Crenshaw as a way to capture the overlapping and interdependent nature of systems of oppression. Building on this foundation Patricia Hill Collins and Sirma Bilge further developed intersectionality as an analytical tool centered around interlocking systems of power. According to their definition, intersectionality explores how, on the one hand, intersecting power dynamics impact social relations on a societal level, and, on the other hand, how they influence individual experiences in everyday life. Moreover, as an analytical tool, intersectionality positions categories of race, class, gender, sexuality, and others as "interrelated and mutually shaping one another", becoming "a way of understanding and explaining complexity in the world, in people, and in human experiences" (Hill Collins & Bilge, 2020, p. 2).

When applied to media studies, intersectionality becomes essential in unpacking processes of representation and in/visibility. Drawing on Stuart Hall's (2017) work on representation and meaning-making, it becomes clear that to suggest that media is barely a mirror that reflects reality is a reductive statement to its true power of shaping up who becomes visible and who remains invisible within the public discourse.

Expanding this understanding of visibility, Ahmed's (2007) concept of whiteness as orientation provides a useful lens for examining how power structures organize attention and recognition. In other words, whiteness shapes societal norms, privileges, and access, prioritizing dominant identities and marginalizing minority identities. As Ahmed puts it, it is a structural force that determines how bodies navigate and inhabit spaces: "Whiteness is an orientation that puts certain things within reach. (...) At the same time, whiteness orients bodies in specific directions, affecting what they 'can do.'" (Ahmed, 2007, p. 154). In this sense, whiteness structures moral frameworks that normalize oppression and set the foundations of a hierarchy of visibility.

When it comes to who is perceived as inherently deserving of visibility and who is organically pushed into invisibility, Romania is no different. Although unfortunately still heavily obscured in mainstream media, the country has been systemically prioritizing whiteness over its Roma minority, which reflects deeply in how invisible Roma perspectives are in news coverage.

These dynamics become even more complex when gender intersects with other axes of power. Hamilton et al.'s (2019) concept of femininity premium provides another dimension to these relations:

> The femininity premium may appear to be an advantage based exclusively on gender performance. We argue this is an illusion—and one that obscures the operation of other axes in the matrix of domination. For example, when people swoon over Grace Kelly or Marilyn Monroe as iconic images of feminine beauty, their whiteness is idolized as much as their femininity. (Hamilton et al., 2019, p. 328)

The concept showcases how performing a culturally idealized version of femininity can temporarily lend women individual benefits, but not without legitimizing the very same patriarchal system of oppression. Within Hamilton et al.'s framework, women are portrayed as symbols of virtues, sexual objects, and everything in between—roles that align with the concept of hegemonic femininities actively partaking in the same system of oppression.

Alongside gender, class plays a crucial, yet sometimes minimized role in shaping visibility. Wallis (2015) explores what makes class domination distinct in comparison with other intersecting structures such as gender or race, while making clear that he only thinks of class as primary from a political vantage point (Wallis, 2015, p. 604). He unveils a limitation of existing intersectionality scholarship: that of treating class as "a personal cultural trait, in the manner of

an identity-affiliation" instead of understanding the agency of capital over society within capitalism (Wallis, 2015, p. 618). In relation to the impact of class on gender, he deems that just like white supremacy, male supremacy is thriving indefinitely because of the existence of the ruling class, "because it is integral to the culture that upholds capital and empire" (Wallis, 2015, p. 616). Ending his argument sharply, Wallis recognizes that despite individual efforts to stray away from class affiliation, dominance can only end through dismantling the power of "its most intransigent members" (Wallis, 2015, p. 617).

In the same vein, Jakobsson and Stiernstedt (2018) ask the question of who gets to have an active voice in Swedish television, and discover that the ruling class, while able to speak to members of different classes, is rarely spoken to by members of classes below their own (Jakobsson & Stiernstedt, 2018, p. 522). But Swedish television is not singular in showcasing a "social hierarchy of voice and authority that reproduces and legitimizes already existing social hierarchies" (Jakobsson & Stiernstedt, 2018, p. 522)—it reflects the universality of class in/visibility. Jakobsson and Stiernstedt conclude that overlooking social class in media coverage and ignoring it in media production go hand in hand.

These layered hierarchies of visibility become even more nuanced in the context of Eastern Europe. In their article "What to Wear for Whiteness?", Krivonos and Diatlova (2020) question the contrasting position of the Eastern European female body compared to Western European norms of white femininity. They specifically zoom in on the role of over-sexualization in the construction of Eastern European femininity: while white femininity is "sexually 'liberated' but respectable (...), racialized Eastern European femininity serves to reaffirm the norm of white Western—and Nordic—femininity" (Krivonos & Diatlova, 2020, p. 127). In other words, Eastern European femininity is the "semi-periphery" that helps maintain the "core" represented by Western white femininity (Krivonos & Diatlova, 2020, p. 127). This is true about the perception of Eastern European women outside of Eastern Europe, but it also reflects how Eastern European femininity is more and more homogeneously constructed even within Eastern European countries, which can be seen particularly in the media.

In order to adapt intersectionality to the empirical reality of this research, it is essential to also consider the second largest ethnic minority of Romania: the Roma community. While

Hungarians represent the primary ethnic minority in the country—6%, compared to the 3.1% Roma population, according to The Robert Schuman Foundation's latest report in December 2025 (Fondation Robert Schuman, 2025)—it is the Roma community that faces systemic discrimination and erasure from public discourse. Turning to the most recent Roma scholarship, researchers such as Durnescu (2025), Voina and Sabău (2025), and Mózes, Klesch, and Feith (2022) all point to the multi-layered oppression of Roma women that can only be fully grasped through an intersectional lens.

This perspective is particularly relevant for the present study, which examines how femicide is made visible in the contemporary Romanian media landscape and further interrogates whose experiences remain systematically excluded from that visibility.

4.4. Media coverage of femicide

Briefly returning to Surette, he identifies five frames that socially construct what he calls "the crime and justice arena" (Surette, 2007, p. 37). It is important to note that while Surette looked at the United States in his examples, the rationale behind his findings can be recognized globally; he even remarks that "crime is nearly universally attributed to individual failings rather than to social conditions" (Surette, 2007, p. 112).

Among the frames he identifies, the social breakdown and the faulty criminal justice system frames stand out the most when assessing how media and entertainment illustrate cases of femicide. The former showcases the attribution of blame to family and community disintegration: crime is shaped, then, as a consequence of domestic phenomena such as divorce or out-of-wedlock births (Surette, 2007, p. 39) instead of the result of a plurality of structural factors. Similarly, the latter—the faulty criminal justice system frame—focuses on episodic failures of the law organs rather than factors such as gender inequality, which are rarely if ever connected to femicide cases, let alone femicide as a recurring pattern. As Surette highlights, this frame implies that crimes are committed largely due to offenders "knowing they can get away with them because the police are handcuffed by liberal judges and the prisons are revolving doors" (Surette, 2007, p. 38)—which, while not untrue, is reductive, being but a piece of a much bigger puzzle.

Building on this critique of episodic and individualized explanations, Bouzerdan and Whitten-Woodring (2018) demonstrate that news coverage of femicide often isolates incidents from broader patterns of human rights violations. This tendency limits the potential of femicide to be perceived as a systemic issue, reinforcing fragmented interpretations rather than structural awareness.

Parallel scholarship on feminist activism and digital media has explored how social movements attempt to counteract depoliticized representations. Xiong, Cho, and Boatwright's (2019) study of the #MeToo movement illustrates how hashtag activism employs collective and systematic frames to rearticulate individual experiences of violence as manifestations of broader power relations. This highlights the framing potential of feminist digital activism, while also pointing out the disconnect between activist discourse and mainstream news practices. Together, these perspectives point to a persistent gap between increased visibility and meaningful reframing, a tension that remains underexplored in many national contexts.

In previous femicide media research, scholars such as Richards et al. (2011) found that news coverage of intimate partner homicide often fails to connect cases as part of a societal issue. Instead, they are treated individually as homicides, without a clear distinction of the domestic violence factor. They noted as well that in early research, indirect tactics of victim blaming were present, such as substance abuse or mental health struggles, as well as indirect blaming language—these factors were considered in their own study and concluded to still be present, even if in smaller percentages (Richards et al., 2011, p. 190). Moreover, they looked into source presence throughout their sample and found that advocates against domestic violence were only used in 6% of the articles. The conclusion of the study was that "Victim blaming is not a condition of a certain journalist, newspaper, or state—even the effort of a strong domestic violence coalition does not protect against victim blaming" (Richards et al., 2011, p. 196), but that despite the presence of victim blaming, they could also identify examples of ideal coverage of femicide that give voice to experts in domestic violence and frame femicide as a form of intimate partner violence (Richards et al., 2011, p.196). Yet, the prevalence of episodic frames over thematic frames is still a pressing concern.

This point is further strengthened by Gillespie et al.'s (2013) comparative framing analysis of femicide coverage where femicide was or was not defined as domestic violence. The results clearly showcased that identifying femicide as domestic violence is crucial in interpreting media frames and that in the articles that did not distinguish femicide as an act of domestic violence it is more likely that the case is described as merely another homicide (Gillespie et al., 2013, p. 237).

More recent scholarship suggests a similar paradox. Aldrete and Fernández-Ardèvol (2023) identify that even in contexts where femicide has gained increased visibility as a social issue, the visibility did not translate to structural framing. Instead, episodic narratives remained dominant, suggesting that recognition alone is insufficient to reshape entrenched media rationales.

In the Romanian context, existing research reflects these broader patterns. Studies by Balica (2021), Balica, Marinescu, and Balica (2020), and Rovenţa-Frumuşani and Stoica (2023) highlight persistent patterns of sensationalism, victim-blaming, and the individualized framing of violence against women. Simultaneously, these studies point to the marginalization of cases involving women from lower socio-economic backgrounds, rural areas, or ethnic minorities within media coverage.

This body of literature unveils a critical gap between visibility and structural interpretation—which the present study addresses by examining whether increased media attention to femicide in Romania corresponds to a meaningful shift in framing, or whether episodic and individualized narratives continue to prevail.

5. Method

5.1. Ontological and epistemological foundations

Before outlining the research design and explaining the choice of a mixed-methods approach, it is essential to begin at its ontological and epistemological roots. Earlier in the Literature Review it has already been established that in the realm of media, frames are used to construct meaning and shape public understanding of social and political issues (Entman, 1993). This positions framing analysis—a method extensively used in feminist media studies—within a social constructionist stance, where knowledge is boundless and actively architectured by different social actors (Bryman, 2015, p. 29).

Studying frames, then, has the potential to reveal ideological beliefs and assumptions embedded in society—but it is equally important to acknowledge that it mirrors knowledge constructed by the researcher themself, who presents within the context of their study a particular version of reality that lives within a well-defined social space and time (Bryman, 2015, p. 29). In this thesis, that social arena is represented by Romanian media, and the time period chosen spans across two years, 2024 and 2025 (although, as it will be revealed soon, the most abundant segment of this timeframe is found in the latter 6 months of 2025).

This leads to the importance of complementing the qualitative, epistemologically interpretivist, and ontologically constructionist nature of framing analysis as a method with the orientation towards objectivism that quantitative content analysis implies. While noting that the quantitative analysis that will ensue in this case does include variables largely stemming from framing theories, it sets out to measure, quantify, and map out the visibility of femicide in a deductive manner that places emphasis on testing theories (Bryman, 2015, p. 32).

As such, quantitative content analysis builds a systematic, quantifiable overview of femicide visibility across Romanian news coverage. Then, framing analysis adds interpretive depth, revealing ideological assumptions, public understanding, and constructions of meaning embedded in the already assembled map of femicide visibility.

5.2. Research design and mixed-methods approach

With the purpose of outlining femicide news coverage and examining the construction of frames within the high-profile cases that define femicide coverage in Romania in most recent times, the thesis employs a mixed-methods design that combines a quantitative step with a qualitative one. The sequential logic behind this is that the qualitative stage has the purpose of lending depth to the breadth outlined through the quantitative stage.

A deductive quantitative content analysis informed by framing theories is employed firstly to craft an overview of recent femicide coverage trends (2024-2025). Then, an inductive framing analysis is used to capture how the three high-profile femicide cases of 2025 were constructed through frames and what understandings of femicide these emerging frames make available to the public.

As Entman notes, framing analysis operates by identifying which elements of reality are selected and made salient in a text, and which are left out—a logic that informs both analytical stages of this study (Entman, 1993, p. 53). The quantitative stage seeks to use predetermined categories operationalized systematically in a codebook (Bryman, 2015, p. 285) to unveil how prevalent femicide news coverage is in Romanian media, and how femicide is made visible within this pool of news articles semantically and conceptually. The qualitative stage is applied to a smaller sample as that allows for a closer exploration of the text, and a framing application model is built on the concepts and theories discussed in the Literature Review.

The quantitative and qualitative methods produced distinct, yet complementary insights: the first allowed for a systematic overview of news reports of femicide, helping map out the current state of femicide coverage within Romanian media, while the second provided an in-depth, granular, contextual understanding of how frames were constructed and combined within specific high-profile cases of femicide during the chosen timeframe.

5.3. Data collection and sampling rationale

5.3.1. Data collection

In the very early stages of mapping out all the news articles that reported on femicide cases between January 1st 2024 and December 31st 2025, a rather unexpected discovery was made: the word *femicide* only started being used frequently in describing cases in May-June 2025, after the high-profile case of Teodora Marcu. This discovery, alongside the subsequent adoption of the femicide bill in Romania's legal code in March 2026, ended up changing the trajectory of the sampling rationale. Although earlier using a mix of keywords that were not limited to variations of the word *femicide* was considered, the focus became news articles that specifically identify and build their reporting around the concept of femicide.

The reasoning behind this is that it is already known what happened before increased visibility and (digital) activism: not naming the act of femicide only contributed to a fogbound understanding of the structural nuances behind femicide and gender-based violence. But what is at hand now—the existence and popularization of this term, apace with activist efforts and organizational pressures to legally conceptualize femicide—lends a new dimension to media portrayals of femicide in Romania. The era of blatantly sensationalist reporting structured around phrases such as *breathless*, *tragic ending*, or *crime of passion* seems to have been replaced by a new trend of superficial concern hidden behind the term *femicide* without actual assignation of blame and accountability, or public understanding of the structural systems at play that contribute to the prevalence of women's deaths.

Initially, in the first pool of material, all the articles that mentioned the Romanian word for femicide (*femicid*) in the headline or the body of the article were amassed, including national and international cases, national and international legislative updates, protests or other manifestations of activism, reports and statistics, cultural moments. The timeframe chosen was January 1st 2024 - December 31st 2025, as it captured the transition from extremely low visibility to a sudden recognition of femicide due to the high-profile case of Teodora Marcu (May 31st 2025). Due to lack of access to a national database, several search engines were tested before concluding that Google was yielding the most results and disposed of the best advanced search filters (more

specifically, the News tab in Google). Other engines, such as DuckDuckGo, Brave, or Bing, did not have a Romanian language or location filter. In order to avoid algorithmic bias and achieve triangulation, the online archives of news outlets were filtered for the word *femicid* when possible. Of course, these archives follow the individual biases of each outlet; they might use the word *femicid* as a filter or tag on specific articles and not on others. Articles that had the *femicid* tag, but in reality reported the death or attempted death of a man, for example, were excluded. Romanian-language articles originating from Moldovan outlets were excluded, but initially Romanian branches of foreign outlets were taken into consideration. The keywords searched for in Google News were *femicid* and *femicid România*, and no Romanian news outlet was excluded in the process, no matter the type (mainstream, independent, tabloid, etc.).

This initial approach was informed by the intention to map out the visibility of femicide as a concept and term across Romanian media, tracing how news outlets reported the killings of women and identified these cases as instances of femicide. It was an intentional decision to leave the door open for a variety of avenues when it came to results, including what and how different outlet types reported on between femicide cases, femicide legislation, protests, etc.

However, because these searches resulted in 495 unique articles, new filters were added in order to reach a more realistic sample for the quantitative content analysis, taking into account that this stage represents only a half of the final research. In this sense, while the restrictions applied could indicate that the final sample carries characteristics of a convenience sample, it is more accurately understood as a purposive sample built around clearly fledged out inclusion criteria (Bryman, 2015, p. 409).

5.3.2. Defining quantitative sample

As a consequence, external cases were removed altogether, as well as local and regional articles that reported on the same cases as the national outlets to avoid repetitive, low-quality, or shortened content. In order to ensure that the final sample is focused on just Romania, articles reporting international femicide cases were excluded, despite the inherent value of how news outlets reported on legislative progress regarding femicide in other countries (for example, Italy was particularly mentioned very frequently).

Juridice.ro was excluded because it identifies as a legal professionals' portal rather than a news outlet. Similarly, other exclusions encompass business, economy, or religion focused websites that prioritized their respective fields in their communication. Their reporting of femicide cases or legislative discussions was interpreted as more of a limited point of intersection between news outlets and magazines, blogs, or forums.

Romanian branches of international publications and radio websites were excluded due to external ownership influence and reliance on other outlets' reporting respectively, while television-affiliated outlets (such as Știrile ProTV) were retained given television's dominance in Romanian media consumption. Cultural topics (e.g. theater performances about femicide) and political communication (press releases on parties' websites) were also excluded.

The final quantitative sample consists of 198 unique articles that report on femicide cases within Romania during the 01/01/2024-31/12/2025 timeframe. The sampling rationale was that articles must report on a national femicide case or reference at least one case, a cluster of cases, or the growing phenomenon of femicide. As such, this sample includes protests, legislative discussions, statements by political figures, statistics, alongside reporting on individual cases. A special interest was dedicated to observing if and how official statements, reports, legislative progress are linked to or originate from a specific case garnering particularly high exposure. Additionally, another interest was whether 2025 cases were addressed independently from 2024 cases or statistics pertaining to previous years.

However, when finalizing the sample and jotting down the articles' publishing dates, only one article remained from 2024—all the other ones had been removed because they either covered international cases or global/regional/national statistics that were not linked to specific cases. This in itself represented a valuable early finding, confirming that femicide as a named concept entered Romanian media discourse surrounding national cases only in the second half of 2025—which further shaped both the analytical focus and the effective timeframe of the research. A comprehensive table including all 198 articles with translated headlines can be provided upon request.

5.3.3. Defining qualitative sample

If the quantitative content analysis prioritizes taking the pulse of the Romanian news media of 2024-2025 in order to identify how femicide is represented, framing analysis is then employed to dive into the three most high-profile femicide cases of 2025: Teodora Marcu (25th case of the year), Anda Gyurca (28th case of the year), and Mihaela Mitrache (51st case of the year)—a brief description of each case is available in Appendix 1. The reason behind choosing these cases was that they represent the most high-profile cases of femicide in 2025 (and in recent years), all leading to mass public reactions, NGO mobilization, large protests across the country, and institutional debates over legislative progress.

However, despite being similar in that they were all recognized as instances of femicide, garnered attention, and raised serious questions about the application of law in Romania—its many blind spots and deficiencies—the nuances in reporting differed based on context details, and most of all, based on the victims, perpetrators, and their particular relationships.

Although the cases are referred to using a variety of names in the press—as seen in the quantitative sample—they are most known by the victims' first names. In the context of this thesis, they will be referred to as Case 25, Case 28, and Case 51, following Stop Femicidelor's documentation of 2025 femicide cases. This is an intentional decision meant to return the focus to a point of ethical academic objectivity. By removing the victims' first names as the primary identifiers of the femicides, the cases are no longer following a pattern of profiting off of women's suffering after their death through clickbait headlines and sensationalist details about their lives, often taken out of context; all the while deliberately reducing or erasing altogether perpetrators' presence, which significantly minimizes their agency and responsibility.

For each case three articles were selected to analyze in-depth. While referring to the quantitative sample to identify the most representative articles for each case, factors such as popularity, length (prioritizing more detailed articles over short updates), and originality (avoiding articles that repeated the same exact information) were also taken into consideration. Rather than focusing on specific outlets, the main priority was to identify three different typologies of articles for each case: a case report, a deep-dive into the relationship between the victim and the

perpetrator, and an update regarding public reaction and aftermath on a larger scale (such as institutional or legislative impact).

These three typologies of articles have the purpose of showcasing different stages of visibility and functions of news reporting, which ultimately correspond to unique objectives of framing. In assessing these three different perspectives over the chosen femicide cases, an evolution of frames can be outlined: how feminist terminology emerges, when institutional response begins occupying space in reports, how the relationship between victim and perpetrator is constructed after the initial reporting of the case.

Although case reports and articles depicting the aftermath were easier to identify and select, finding articles that depicted the relationship between the victim and the perpetrator in a relatively balanced manner—without focusing on just one or the other—was harder to accomplish. The articles that contained the most details about the victim and the perpetrator had a more sensationalist tone, while the other types of articles (report and aftermath) were generally spread quite homogeneously between neutral and sensationalist tones, as confirmed by the quantitative results as well.

As a result, the final sample reflects both articles that were coded in the quantitative stage due to their use of the term *femicide*, and articles that do not mention femicide at all, but report the case. Although articles were not chosen based on outlet, outlet type, and tone, a balanced mix was maintained in order to exemplify a large range of reporting of femicide cases, making the sample very relevant and representative for how femicide is framed in Romanian online news. The outlets and outlet types in this sample were: Digi24 and KanalD (television-affiliated, KanalD being known for usually employing a reporting tone most compatible with tabloids), Snoop and Context (independent), and Adevărul (mainstream). A table containing the framing sample is available upon request.

5.4. Quantitative Content Analysis

5.4.1. Codebook and operationalization

The codebook was structured around five variable categories, each operationalized in direct relation to the research aim and questions. Firstly, identification variables—which include publication date, outlet, and outlet type—have the purpose of setting up the basic descriptive parameters of the sample and enable comparisons across mainstream, independent, tabloid, and television-affiliated outlets. Then, added to that are a reference scope variable (identifying the number of femicide cases addressed within each article) and a femicide visibility variable which track both the semantic and conceptual presence of femicide as a term within articles, differentiating between headline usage, central concept, marginal mention, or absence (save for the femicide tag within the news outlet's archiving system). This distinction is essential in answering RQ1.

Additionally, framing variables captured frame type (episodic, thematic, mixed), responsibility attribution, and problem definition, drawing from Entman (1993) and Iyengar (1994). Thematic framing, in this context, was ascribed to articles that placed the femicide case within a developing pattern of similar cases, while mixed framing was assigned to articles that displayed mostly episodic framing, yet mentioned—even if just shortly—the context of growing femicide cases. Gendered representation variables were split between victim portrayal and perpetrator portrayal, while the tone variable assessed the level of sensationalism present in the article from neutral to moderately, and then highly sensationalist. These variables were informed by Surette (2007) and Rolle et al.'s (2020) concepts surrounding ideal victimhood, deviant perpetrator representation, and crime aestheticization through sensationalism.

Lastly, binary intersectional variables were established to track the presence or absence of structural factors, gender, and social categories such as class, age, ethnicity, and rural or urban membership. To this, a dominant voice variable was added to identify the actors that have the most influence over femicide news coverage—categories ranging from authorities, individual political or public figures, experts, activists, witnesses (family, neighbors, and, in the case of

posthumous quotes or attempted femicide cases, victim's voice). The codebook is available in Appendix 2.

5.4.2. Coding process and resolving overlaps

A central methodological decision concerned the distinction between descriptive mentions and interpretive framing, particularly within the intersectional variables. Surface-level descriptive information was coded as absence of structural or intersectional awareness, while interpretive framing, even when merely marginal, was coded as presence. For example, in one article the ages of both the victim and the perpetrator were stated and the age gap was easily calculable, but no connection was made to concepts such as grooming or power imbalance due to a problematic age difference. Despite the inferential potential of this information, it was coded as absence of intersectional framing because the text itself did not activate that meaning.

This principle of coding what the text pushed into visibility rather than what could be inferred was applied consistently across all intersectional variables with the objective to maintain analytical objectivity. In fact, a similar careful distinction was made to frame type. Articles debating legislative progress in reaction to a singular case without positioning it within a broader pattern of gender-based violence were coded as episodic rather than thematic. The reason behind this was that the structural connection was missing from the framing, even if, again, it could have been considered present implicitly.

With each potential overlap, the coding strategy prioritized returning to the research aim as a reflexive strategy of anchoring: the mapping of semantic and conceptual visibility of femicide. This approach to internal consistency aligns with Bryman's focus on coding transparency as a foundation for reliability in single-researcher content analysis studies (Bryman, 2015, p. 157). Furthermore, a reflexive journal was maintained throughout the coding process to document decisions, note ambiguities, and ensure that interpretive choices were still traceable and consistent across the entire sample.

Lastly, following Bryman's (2015) guide, the variables were defined in the IBM SPSS statistics program, where the coded data was imported. Descriptive analysis was employed in order to analyze resulting frequencies and cross-tabulations.

5.5. Framing Analysis

The framing analysis zooms in on the three high-profile femicide cases of 2025—the murders of Teodora Marcu, Anda Gyurca, and Mihaela Mitrache—in order to examine how media narratives construct meaning around femicide. Drawing on framing theory, the analysis will identify dominant frames, with a particular focus on the distinction between episodic and thematic frames, attribution of causal and treatment responsibility, and the presence or absence of structural explanations (such as gender inequality). This qualitative step provides a deeper understanding of how individual cases are narratively constructed within the media.

5.5.1. Analytical framework and framing application model

From an analytical approach point of view, inductive and deductive elements are combined. Deductively, the study draws on existing theoretical frameworks—that will be detailed below—in guiding the identification of frames and analytical categories. Inductively, the analysis remains open to emerging patterns within the data, allowing for the identification of framing practices specific to the context of Romanian media. Taken together, this two-fold approach ensures theoretical grounding, as well as empirical sensitivity.

Before diving into the tools that informed the framing analysis, it is essential to define how the frames were identified to begin with. Among the elements considered were attribution patterns (responsibility attribution and problem definition), narrative emphasis, contextualization, actor visibility, and moral evaluation across the sample.

Rooted in the theoretical chapter preceding the analysis, the framing application model employed here is primarily based on Entman's conceptualization of framing, interwoven with subsequent nuances provided by scholars such as Iyengar and Surette. Departing from the salience and omission of different pieces of information, further depth was added to the analysis by pinpointing the construction of a hierarchy of visibility, in order to assess how femicide is made sense of and addressed in Romanian online news.

As dominant voices showed up in the material as early as the quantitative coding stage, and regional and national authorities were especially prevalent, it became analytically evident that

Entman's (2004) political communication concept of cascading activation will be useful in observing how ideas and frames flow from institutions and power figures to the general public.

Because the actor category Surette's (2007) calls claims makers—such as nonprofits or activists—ultimately brought the concept of *femicide* into the Romanian mainstream and pushed for its institutional recognition, it is important to look at how these voices are borrowed and used through frames, as well as how their very presence might be the result of pressure they intentionally put on newsrooms to maintain balance and objectivity in news coverage.

Due to the long history of mistreatment of domestic violence and gender-based violence in Romania, distinguishing between episodic and thematic frames as well as between causal responsibility and treatment responsibility (Iyengar, 1994) further supported a better understanding of how femicide is packaged by the media and offered to the public.

Additionally, headline construction is analyzed through conceptions of sensationalism and clickbait (Ittefaq, 2018), and particularly within the set of articles depicting the relationship between the victim and the perpetrator, the stereotypes carved out by Surette (2007)—such as the ideal victim trope—are borrowed in order to observe how femicide as a concept is applied to specific context in news coverage.

Lastly, frame presence and frequency (Hänggli, 2012) and frame context (Bartholomé et al., 2017) are the scaffolding upon which these undertones are added. Within a qualitative method that can sometimes slip off the path of pure, undebated objectivity, documenting and analyzing context, presence, and frequency represent the rigorous pillars of the analysis.

5.5.2. Coding process and resolving overlaps

Each article was analyzed through a set of questions derived from the framing application model. The full sample was self-translated from Romanian to English—an example is included in Appendix 3 and other translations are available upon request. Following an initial familiarization with the sample, a coding table was generated to systematically document answers across all nine articles, allowing recurring patterns to surface visually before frames were formally identified. The questions guiding this process are included in Appendix 4.

5.5.3. Generating frames

Frames were generated inductively from recurring patterns identified across the coded articles in. Analytical categories combining dominant voice, framing type, tone, responsibility attribution, and intersectional perspectives were grouped into clusters of shared characteristics. These clusters were then formalized into named frames and ordered into a progressive spectrum reflecting how close each frame brings Romanian news coverage to a more comprehensive structural understanding of femicide.

The process of generating frames unfolded progressively across three analytical steps. Firstly, each article was coded individually through the framing questions outlined above. After that, in the second step, recurring similarities and contrasts were observed through cross-case and cross-typology examinations, which allowed patterns to emerge across articles that shared dominant voices, responsibility attribution, framing logic, and representation practices. Lastly, in the final step, these recurring patterns were consolidated into broader interpretive frames through iterative pattern recognition and comparative differentiation.

Some frames peaked early on due to high frequency and consistent characteristics—particularly those related to the dramatization of femicide and victim/perpetrator stereotypical portrayal. The most analytically layered step was distinguishing between frames that were closer to structural recognition, as they required a more meticulous look into how or whether social categories and intersectional thinking were activated. Ultimately, the near-absence of intersectional awareness was what differentiated between two otherwise similar frames.

5.6. Ensuring research quality

From a research quality standpoint, internal consistency was supported through the use of detailed codebooks for both stages of analysis, as well as repeated coding checks and transparent reporting of procedures in the appendices. The study maintains analytical validity by keeping findings descriptive and interpretive, in line with the research design and sample size. A reflexive journal kept throughout the entire thesis writing and research processes further supported transparency and consistency across both the steps of analysis.

5.6.1. Reliability

Reliability refers to "the extent to which findings can be reproduced or replicated by another researcher" (Brennen, 2017). In qualitative research, absolute replication is impossible due to the dynamic, constructivist nature of social contexts. In fact, scholars acknowledge that "it is impossible to 'freeze' a social setting and the circumstances of an initial study to make it replicable" (Bryman, 2015). However, external reliability can be reached through procedural transparency and rigor, which enable confidence and replication in principle even in cases of specific cultural contexts enclosed in a certain moment in time and space.

While in research teams decisions can be discussed in order to reach internal reliability, in the case of single-researcher projects, this proves to be a challenge (Bryman, 2015). To alleviate this potential difficulty, a reflection journal was kept throughout the research process where quantitative coding decisions, interpretive framing reasoning, and the very crystallization of emerging frames were documented. In this sense, internal reliability was achieved by maintaining coding consistency and engaging in transparent self-reflection.

While acknowledging the interpretive nature of framing analysis and the ways in which it can hinder precise replication, this research ensures that the findings are dependable through systematic and transparent documentation of the analytic procedures. This is maintained throughout both research stages in order to guarantee that the methodological logic can be followed, the quality of the coding assessed, and a new study within similar parameters reproduced. Nurturing reliability strengthens the general level of trustworthiness of this research.

5.6.2. Validity

In qualitative research, validity "concerns how confident we can be that we have interpreted our findings in the 'right way'—that is we are showing the credibility of our work" (Faulkner & Atkinson, 2024); essentially, qualitative validity refers to the accuracy and the credibility of the findings. In this research project, validity concerns whether the quantitative content analysis and framing analysis accurately capture how femicide is documented and represented in Romania through news coverage, and whether the conclusions resulted are rooted in the data.

Keeping in mind that framing analysis has a social constructivist philosophy at its core, the meanings generated are inherently dependent on context, making generalizability in this case bound by Romania's specific cultural, political, and social context in the analyzed time period. However, validity can still be increased through triangulation, reflexivity, and transparency.

Triangulation is present through both data triangulation—combining quantitative content analysis with framing analysis allows cross-validation of patterns and perspectives—and source triangulation—mixing different types of news outlets to paint a more accurate picture of femicide framing across Romanian news. To add on to this, maintaining a reflection journal with the purpose of methodically documenting coding decisions and accounting for interpretive influences, reduces the chance of bias occurrence and builds reflexivity. Honest documentation of analytical procedures also offers transparency, helping readers trace interpretation back to the original data. As a result, despite the results being context-dependent, they can still provide a point of departure and an analytical framework for further studies.

5.6.3. Ethical considerations

Several ethical considerations informed both the data collection and analytical stages of this research. Because of the study's analytical focus centering around the violent deaths of women, there is a need for particular sensitivity to how victims are referenced throughout the analysis. Bryman's chapter on Ethics and politics in social research (2015) was referenced in building a solid code of ethics within this thesis.

As outlined earlier in the sampling rationale section, the three high-profile femicide cases examined in the qualitative stage are referred to by the corresponding number in digital activism platform Stop Femicidelor's documentation framework for 2025 femicide cases (*stop femicidelor ref.*): Case 25, Case 28, and Case 51, respectively. This decision was made intentionally with the purpose of avoiding the reproduction of the very pattern of victim-centric naming that usually dominates news coverage—an element that this thesis sets out to examine critically. Similarly, direct quotes from news articles are used for analytical purposes only, rather than for their overly emotional or sensationalist content.

Lastly, the researcher's position as an insider to some social contexts (Romanian society and culture, Romanian language), yet an outsider to others (particularly class, ethnicity, and rural

membership), was acknowledged throughout the reflexive journal. The aim behind this documentation was to reduce any interpretive bias that might arise in the analysis of intersectional framing.

6. Results and analysis

This section presents the findings of the study in two stages that reflect the mixed-methods design. Firstly, the quantitative content analysis will map out the patterns of femicide coverage across Romanian news media, focusing on hierarchy of visibility, usage of femicide terminology, and attribution of responsibility. Secondly, the framing analysis will offer an in-depth examination of three high-profile cases, exploring how media narratives construct responsibility, assign meaning, and include—or omit—structural and intersectional explanations. Distinguishing between episodic and thematic frames will be a central focus, as well as identifying whose voices and perspectives are made in/visible within media coverage.

6.1. Quantitative results and analysis

The quantitative content analysis maps femicide coverage across 198 news articles published between January 1st 2024 and December 31st 2025 in Romania, examining patterns of visibility and salience, framing, responsibility attribution and causality, and intersectional representation. The results are organized across sub-sections as follows: a descriptive overview of the sample, an analysis of responsibility attribution and framing patterns, an examination of victim and perpetrator portrayal, and an assessment of structural and intersectional framing.

6.1.1. Descriptive overview of the sample

In the entire sample, only one article was published in 2024 (A69), with all other 197 articles having been published between June and December 2025. The most popular date among the sample was November 10th 2025, corresponding to one of the three high-profile cases (Case 51), with 32 unique articles published on that date. The first article mentioning femicide in 2025 was in June, when Case 25 occurred, and more specifically as protests ensued. A clear uprise in coverage can be noticed, as articles that define—or, at the very least, classify through tags on the news outlet's website—new cases as femicides increase after Case 25 (Figure 1).

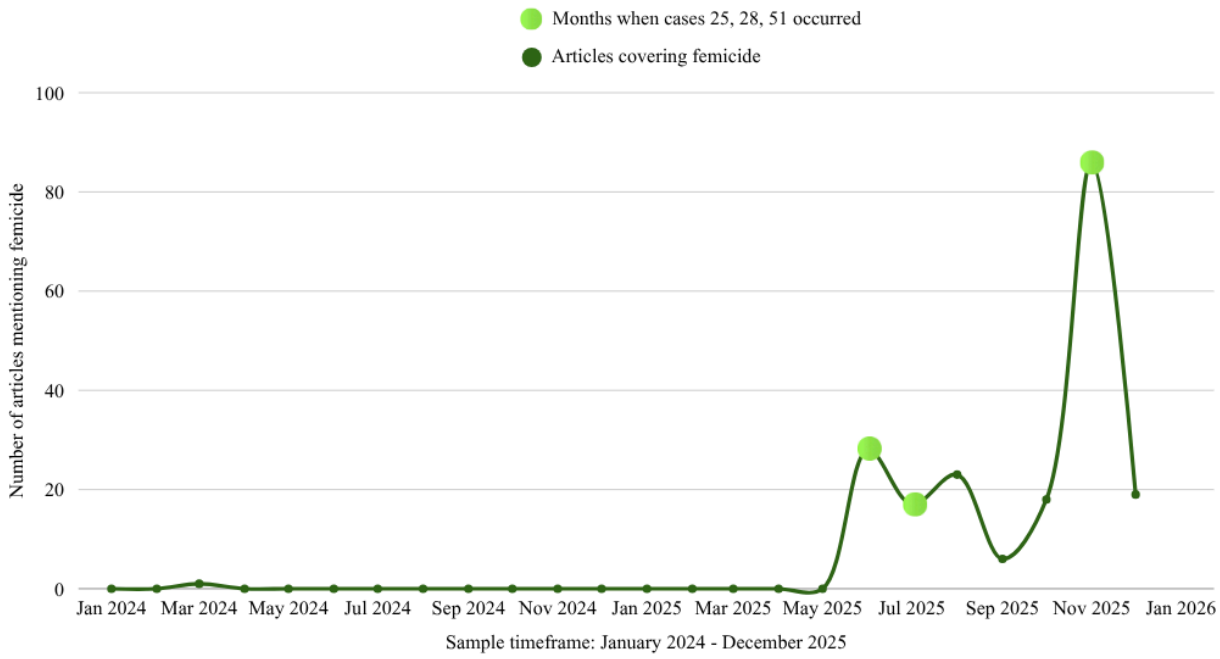


Figure 1. Chronological overview of the sample

The biggest percentage of reporting belongs to television-affiliated news outlets (44.9%) which aligns with television's significant dominance of Romanian media consumption patterns (Marincea, 2023). Naturally, the outlets that provide the most articles are Observator (29 of 198) and Digi24 (23 of 198)—two television-affiliated outlets—followed closely by independent G4Media (20 of 198) and mainstream HotNews (18 of 198).

Table 1. Article distribution according to outlet types

Outlet type	N	%
Mainstream	47	23.7%
Independent	43	21.7%
Tabloid	19	9.6%
Television-affiliated	89	44.9%
Total	198	100%

This mirrors insights derived from Popa (2011) and Marincea (2023) about Romanian media consumption patterns and the prevalence of television in Romanian society, paired with poor media quality. The dominance of television-affiliated outlets in femicide coverage cannot be seen as an odd occurrence. As Botan (2024) and Popa (2011) both detail, the deprofessionalization of journalism in post-communist Romania has been most acute in commercial television, and the same model was applied to newsrooms: episodic and sensationalist framing practices becoming deeply entrenched in national media.

A deprofessionalized industry produces framing that lends visibility and space to emotional immediacy, not structural awareness. This is argued through Entman's conceptualization of framing as episodic or thematic, because episodic framing can, as seen in this case, lead to depoliticization, individualization, fragmentation of public perception and understanding. As a result, instead of building the structural awareness that leads to progress, it nurtures emotional immediacy: the public reacts strongly in the moment, but without the recognition of femicide as structural, it cannot push for change.

When it comes to femicide prominence within articles, 53% of the sample focuses on femicide as the central concept within the article, with majority of central framing articles belonging to television-affiliated and mainstream outlets (Figure 2), while 18.7% fail to mention the word past classifying it as a femicide within the news outlet’s search system. The remaining 28.3% register limited presence of femicide in the headline and content of the articles. This point towards a tendency of using terminology without properly connecting it to the concept it is describing. This becomes particularly evident in the situations where femicide is used exclusively in the headline, only as a means to keep track of the growing number of killings of women, meanwhile the content of the articles neglects a comprehensive understanding of the phenomenon and, in a significant amount of instances, singles out the case as an isolated incident.

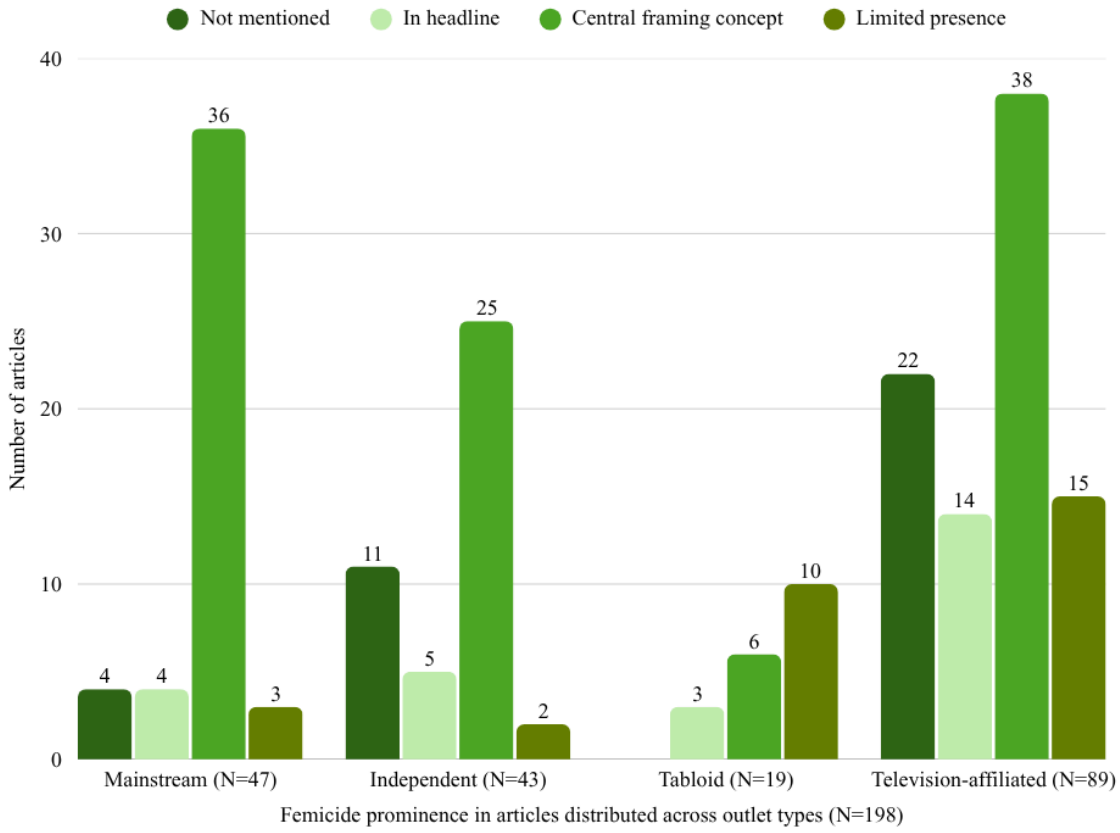


Figure 2. Femicide prominence displayed according to outlet types

When femicide appears only in clickbait headlines or as an archive tag, it functions primarily as a searchable keyword used for algorithmic amplification and search engine optimization tactics, more than it is evidence of a politicized concept. This is the precise dynamic noticed by Noble: algorithms prioritize sensational, emotionally triggering content, reinforcing existing social hierarchies instead of challenging them This gap between semantic presence and conceptual awareness can be further explained through Hänggli's (2012) distinction between frame presence and frame frequency within articles. While femicide is terminologically present across the sample, the frequency of meaningful contextualization remains low, indicating that it has become more of a buzzword.

Even more compelling is the finding that the semantic adoption of the word *femicide* does not bring along evened-out thematic framing: in 50.5% of the sample framing is thematic, yet a striking 37.4% maintains episodic framing (Figure 3). Moreover, when cross-examining frame

types and number of femicide cases addressed in each article (Figure 3), it appears that 55.5% of articles that center a singular case exhibit episodic framing, whilst articles addressing case clusters or femicide as a phenomenon are almost entirely framed thematically (100% and 98.1% respectively). It is, however, important to also note that articles presenting individual cases dominate (66.7%), with articles connecting cases into clusters getting the least coverage (7.1%).

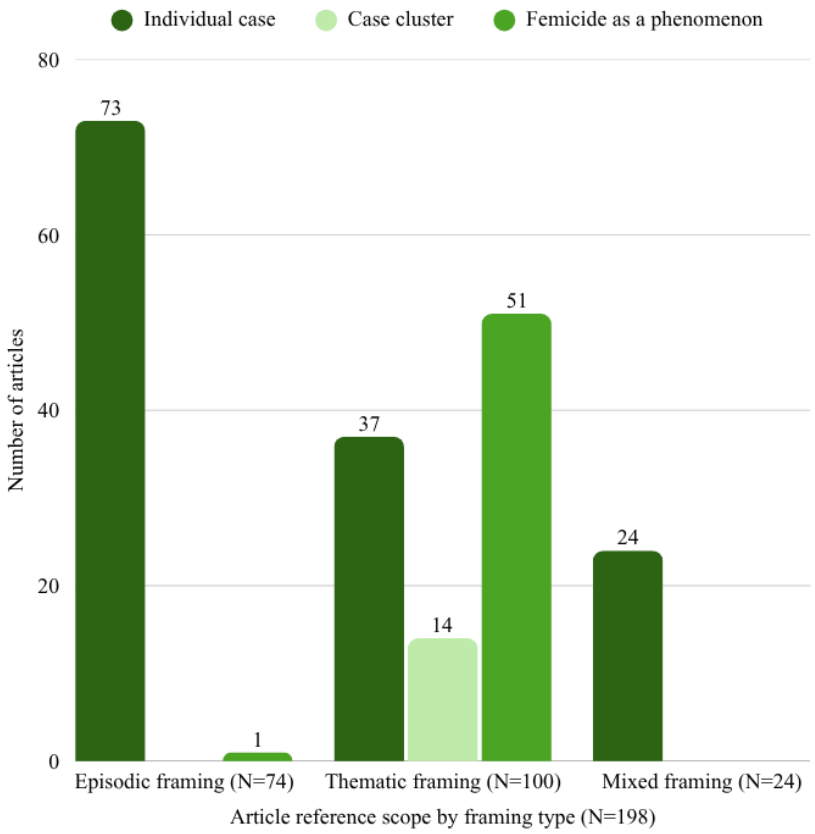


Figure 3. Frame types displayed according to articles' reference scope

As seen here and confirmed in studies such as Xiong, Cho, and Boatwright (2019), activist and expert voices pertaining to social movements and digitalization act as the main counteracting force of these depoliticized representations through systematic frames. Yet, in this sample, the low salience of activist and expert voices alike in femicide coverage can be seen as conducive with low structural and intersectional awareness of femicide.

The logic developed and described by Ittefaq (2018) persists: audiences keep engaging with sensationalist content, which signals to newsrooms that shock value grabs attention, which in

turn generates revenue. As clickbait headlines and sensationalism increase newsworthiness and news value, reflexive structural awareness of femicide remains deprioritized in newsrooms, in a never-ending cycle that feeds into itself, gatekeeping reflexive awareness and ideological progression from the audience.

These results unveil a significant contradiction between semantic visibility of the word *femicide* and structural understanding of the concept of femicide.

6.1.2. Responsibility attribution, identified cause, and framing patterns

Looking at patterns in attribution of responsibility (Table 2), the majority of articles assign individual responsibility (35.9%) or mixed responsibility (33.3%), which is hinting at a combination of individual and institutional blame. The victim is only framed as responsible in 0.5% of articles, while society and culture are assigned responsibility in 8.1% of articles and state and institutions in 22.2%. On defining the cause of the femicide, coverage prioritizes legal institutional failure (35.4%) and relationship conflict (31.8%), while scarcely assigning causality to class factors (1%)—such as poverty, poverty background, or lack of education and access to resources—or gender inequality and gender-based violence (13.1%).

Table 2. Attribution of responsibility and problem definition

Responsibility	N	%	Problem definition	N	%
Individual (perpetrator)	71	35.9%	Not specified	7	3.5%
Victim	1	0.5%	Personal (psychological)	30	15.2%
State/institutions	44	22.2%	Relationship conflict	63	31.8%
Society/culture	16	8.1%	Class factors	2	1.0%
Mixed	66	33.3%	Gender inequality, gender-based violence	26	13.1%
Total	198	100%	Legal/institutional failure	70	35.4%
			Total	198	100%

These recurrences in responsibility attribution and perceived causality do not exist outside of a larger constellation of factors, though. In order to better understand these patterns, it is essential to turn towards the actors whose perspective is most often employed in coverage—both to assess whose viewpoints are highlighted and whose are omitted or minimized. In this regard, the authority voice dominates in 43.4% of articles, 54.5% if clustered with the voices of political or public figures who have given statements about femicide, and who are largely representing the president, Ministers, or other institutional figures (Figure 4).

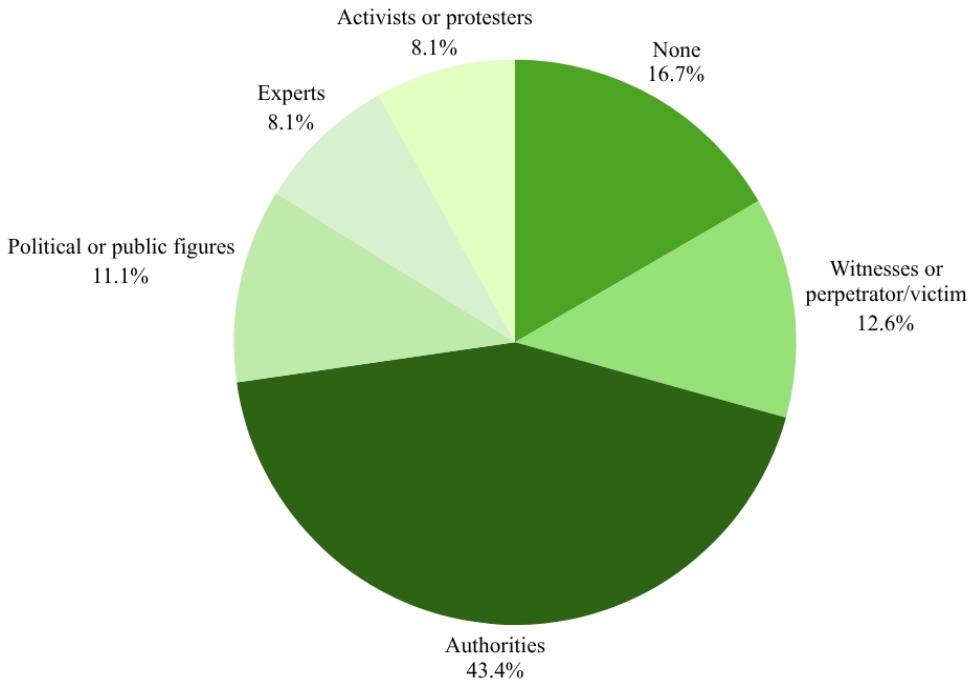


Figure 4. Dominant voice distribution across the sample (N=198=100%)

In this context, responsibility and blame gain a significantly nuanced look: when authority voices hold dominance over femicide framing, responsibility often shifts from the institutions they represent to the individuals that committed the crimes or the circumstances that surrounded the murder, such as conflict or mental health struggles. While legal gaps and inaction of local or regional authority organs is correctly identified in 35.4% of articles as the primary cause of femicide, 47% of articles still assign causality to personal actions, such as relationship conflict or individual blame.

This exemplifies perfectly how Entman's (2004) cascade activation theory can be applied to femicide news coverage. As authority voice dominates throughout the sample, it can be cross-examined with responsibility attribution and problem definition to eventually showcase reactive accountability on the authorities' part and blame-shifting within the spectrum of authority. Actors representing the highest levels of authority (President, Ministers) only respond to cases after they become highly discussed and pushed forward by advocates and protesters. They then ascribe blame to middle authority organs (such as regional courts or judges), which thrust the blame down to even lower authority organs (most often local police enforcement). This results in a make-shift responsibility that crumbles before structural reform can be achieved, due to lack of transparent public accountability. In some cases, the lowest, local-level institutional authorities even shift the blame further down to the actors that possess the lowest authority in society, citizens—in this case, the perpetrator, the victim, or witnesses.

As institutions fail to structurally address femicide outside of the social expectations and the pressure from advocates to do so, it is revealed that despite authorities being criticized by advocates and citizens alike on all levels of the hierarchy, they still maintain their position as dominant interpreters and framers of femicide.

Crosstabulations (Figure 5) reveal that responsibility was attributed to the perpetrator in the articles where the problem was indicated to be a relationship conflict (77.8%), and a similar pattern emerged in articles where the cause was determined to be a personal fault of the perpetrators (56.7%), but in this case, a significant association was made with social responsibility (30%). When the problem is defined as a legal or institutional failure, the state and authority institutions are being assigned responsibility the most; however, there is also a strong presence of mixed responsibility attribution, where blame is shared by local or regional authority organs, the perpetrator, and, in some cases, society.

An additional Chi-Square test of independence was conducted in order to explore whether responsibility attribution varied depending on problem definition. This analysis strengthened the findings, by revealing a significant association between the two ($p<.001$), with Cramer's V being moderately strong (.488).

Mixed responsibility often dilutes structural accountability, as different actors can shift blame to each other. This diffuses blame, which in turn weakens clarity over who is actually in the power-holding position to generate meaningful change.

Notably, class factors, which are only identified as a cause in two articles of the sample—indicating a lack of deep understanding of contributing factors to femicide— are associated with mixed responsibility attribution. Meanwhile, gender inequality is linked to societal and mixed responsibility the most.

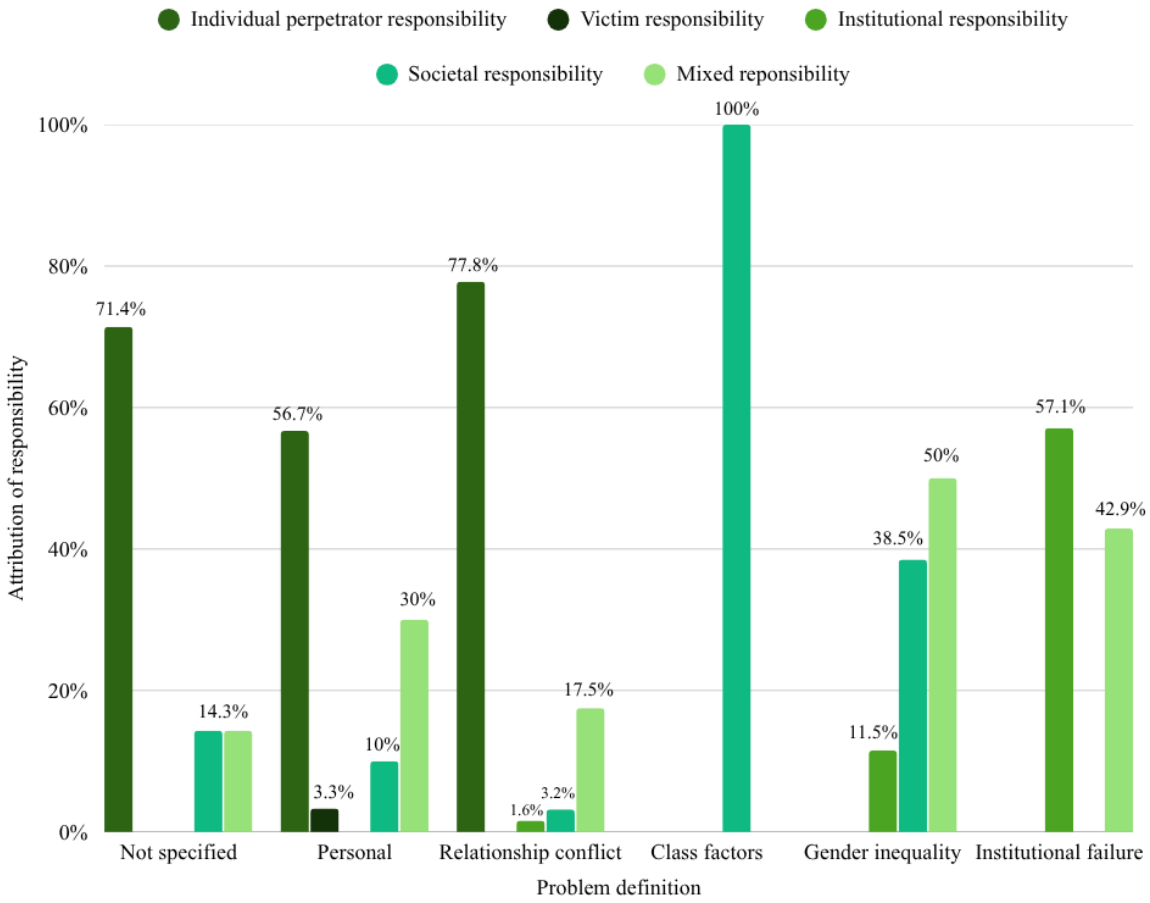


Figure 5. Distribution of responsibility attribution across problem definitions (N=198)

Turning to Iyengar's (1994) differentiation between causal and treatment responsibility (1991), these results show that causal responsibility occurs when individuals or societal attitudes are being assigned the heavy weight of femicide, while treatment responsibility happens when legal failure is identified as the primary cause and the state or institutions are held accountable for

femicide. Here, results show both are present, but treatment responsibility tends to be expressed by expert voices, which are the least salient. Similarly, witnesses or high authority organs/political figures assign responsibility to legal institutions/the state, but it comes with a caveat, namely that solutions in this case are still "customized" to the case discussed within the article. Responsibility cannot be seen as treatment because it does not translate to an alleviation of the structural elements that nurture the emergence of more femicide cases.

The framing types employed are also relative to the dominant voice in news coverage. By running frame type and dominant voice crosstabulations, the following discovery was made: the voice of authorities dominated the most in episodically framed articles (47.7%). Moreover, framing was predominantly thematic in articles where the voices of political figures (95.5%), experts (93.8%), or activists dominated (93.8%). On the flipside, framing was leaning slightly towards episodic in articles where the voices of witnesses dominated (52%).

A parallel can be drawn to Jakobsson and Stiernstedt (2018), who describe Swedish television coverage and production: responsibility attribution and identified causality are shaped by the dominant voice (which results show belongs largely to the authorities). In this context, the legitimization of existing social categories by in/visibility through voice salience and tone show where, when, how others voices (experts, activists, witnesses) live within coverage and what purpose they serve via framing.

Guided by the proven significance of sensationalist and clickbait practices in news coverage (Ittefaq, 2018), tone was also assessed, with articles tilting slightly towards exhibiting a moderately or highly sensationalist tone (51%) as opposed to a neutral one (49%). The tone was more often sensationalist in articles that only discussed one femicide case (59.9%) and more often neutral in articles that addressed femicide case clusters or femicide as a phenomenon (64.3% and 67.3%, respectively). Additionally, articles with neutral reporting tone corresponded with the prioritization of femicide as a central framing concept (54.3%), while moderately or highly sensationalist articles placed femicide either in the headline (53.8%) or scarcely in the body of the article (66.7%).

Consistent with Richards et al.'s (2011) findings that indirect victim blaming can still persist through language and very low emphasis on advocates against domestic violence (6% in their

study), confirmed by the low salience in the results here too. These harmful practices remain widespread in femicide coverage. Furthermore, these results confirm that sensationalist tone, episodic framing, and witness voice amplification often function together to generate newsworthiness through spectacle rather than to form structural understanding. This is a cycle reinforced by algorithmic amplification of emotionally triggering content (Noble, 2018).

6.1.3. Victim and perpetrator representation

Within this sample, victims' portrayal splits almost evenly between neutral (37.9%) and ideal victimhood (36.9%), with a meaningful 14.1% of articles indirectly blaming the victim (Table 8). This can be largely linked to Case 51, with 19% of articles indirectly blaming the victim having been published on November 10th 2025, when Case 51 received increased coverage. Victim portrayal was only absent in 1.5% of articles, as opposed to perpetrator portrayal, which was absent in 11.1% of articles, hinting at a tendency for news coverage to center the victim, especially as an ideal victim.

Perpetrators were predominantly portrayed as monsters or deviants (46%) through descriptions of cruel behavior and a past of violent outbursts; however, 37.9% of articles offer neutral representation and only 5.1% lend perpetrator framing a humanized, sympathetic lens (Table 9).

Table 3. Victim and perpetrator portrayal within the sample

Victim portrayal	N	%	Perpetrator portrayal	N	%
Absent	19	9.6%	Absent	22	11.1%
Ideal victim	73	36.9%	Monster/deviant	91	46.0%
Neutral	75	37.9%	Sympathetic/humanized	10	5.1%
Indirect blame	28	14.1%	Neutral	75	37.9%
Direct blame	3	1.5%	Total	198	100%
Total	198	100%			

Echoing previous research surrounding victim and aggressor stereotypes, particularly Surette's concepts of ideal female victimhood (Surette, 2007), the quantitative results confirm that not only is the victim often portrayed as an ideal target (36.9%) and the perpetrator as a monster or deviant (46%), but these respective representations correspond to each other within this sample (84.9%). Similarly, when one of these actors is portrayed neutrally, it is reflected in the equally neutral framing of the other. The two actors' absence also syncs in 68.2% of the articles, with the victim sometimes being framed as an ideal victim (13.6%) or indirectly blamed (13.6%) in the absence of perpetrator portrayal. This indicates that in contexts where background information about the perpetrator might still be missing, dominant voices, often the authorities', could place blame on the victim herself.

Perpetuating an idealized portrayal of female victimhood is additionally dangerous because it breeds conditional empathy, shaping the public belief that only particular women—in many of these cases, mothers—are worthy of being grieved publicly. This creates the belief that there exist prerequisites for women who are victims of domestic violence in order for them to deserve compassion.

On the other hand, if news coverage maintains that perpetrators are deviants, then the underlying message that is being transmitted is that violence is the result of individual human anomaly, and not the consequence of a faulty, fragmentary system.

As Cuklanz (2013) argues, the individualization of perpetrators as deviants only piles on top of other replications of the same myth that exists everywhere and is particularly embedded in Romanian culture: that violence is the result of a personal anomaly, not the consequence of systemic patriarchy. Despite decades of scholarly critique, this pattern persists in media framing of crime.

Further, Rolle et al.'s (2020) understanding of violence and domestic violence delegitimization as contributing to the aestheticization of violence demonstrates how sensationalist framing's superficial nature leads to the implantation of violence as passionate or transgressive in daily practices. This, simultaneously, denies victims subjectivity and reframes their experiences through external interpretations (Rolle et al., 2020).

Crosstabulations further reveal that instances of the victim being indirectly blamed correspond in 60.8% of the cases with the perpetrator being framed as a deviant (Figure 6). Paired with results showcasing that 67.9% of articles that indirectly blame the victim employ a moderately or highly sensationalist tone, while 82.4% of articles the portray the perpetrator as a deviant, these findings suggest that newsrooms' propensity for sensationalist framing steers femicide coverage away from structural understandings of gender-based violence. Instead, it prioritizes superficial and convenient explanations that individualize the crime and garner more traction through clickbait headlines and dramatizing language.

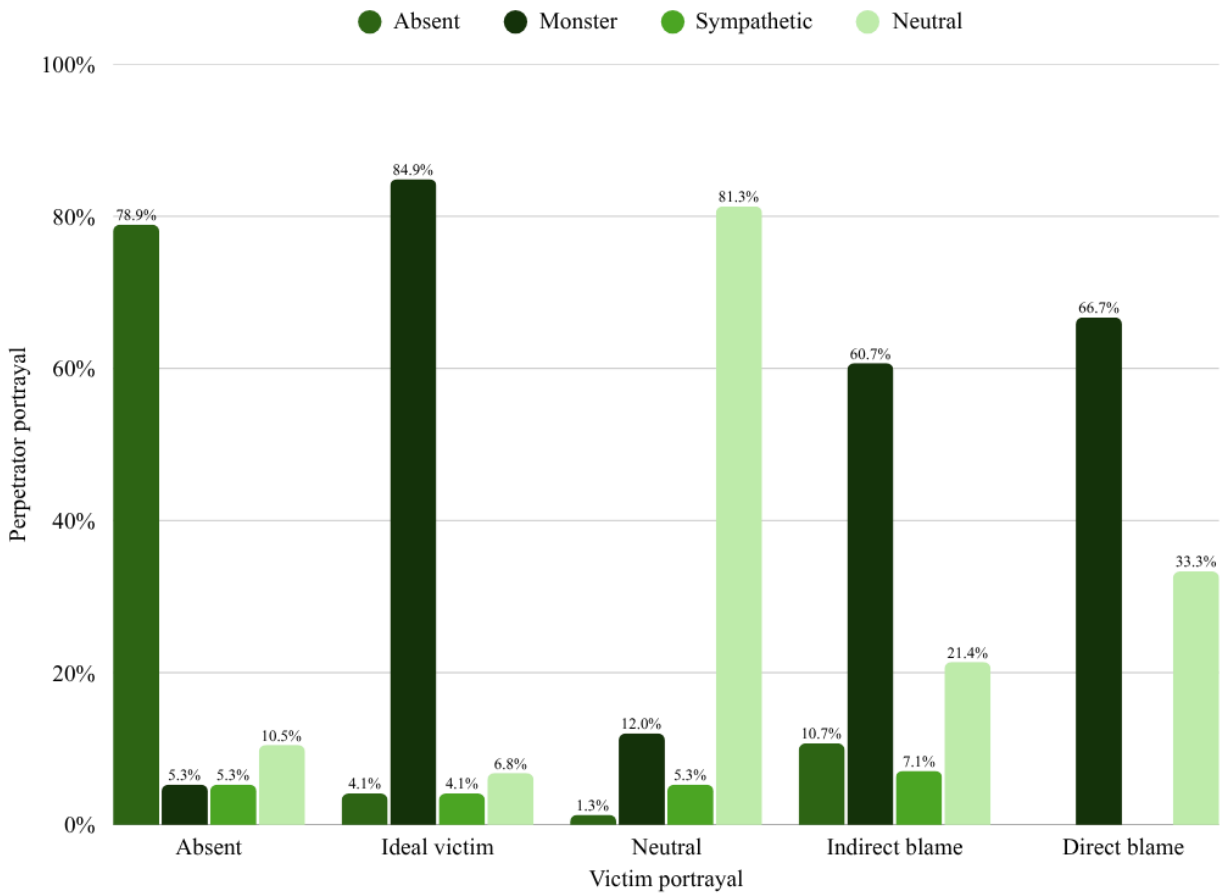


Figure 6. Correlations between victim and perpetrator portrayals (N=198)

As de Lauretis (1989) argues, violence is an en-gendered representation in and of itself. Editorial choices such as sensationalist language or clickbait titles, alongside selective identity markers such as ideal victimhood reproduce symbolic violence. These forms of violence, such as the

dehumanization of femicide victims through superficial, reductive portrayals, reinforce unequal gendered positions even in the very act of reporting on femicide.

These results also affirm patterns already identified and discussed by Romanian scholarship (Balica, 2021; Balica, Marinescu, and Balica 2020; Rovența-Frumușani and Stoica, 2023), confirming that the representational dynamics documented a few years before the heightened femicide visibility of 2025 have persisted.

6.1.4. Structural and intersectional framing

Turning to one of the primary focuses of this research, quantitative results point towards a significant absence of structural factors and gender, gender-based violence, or gender inequality within the sample (Table 11). In 53.5% of the articles structural factors are not mentioned at all, while gender and gender-related issues are mentioned in 60.1% of articles. These results only treat absence or presence, not depth of understanding. The emphasized social categories factoring into femicide are offering more nuanced insights, with gender as a highlighted factor existing in 59.1% of articles. However, age (10.6%), class (8.6%), urban/rural membership (7.6%), and ethnicity (3.5%) are barely considered.

Table 4. Presence of structural and intersectional factors

Structural and intersectional factors	N	%
Structural factors	92	46.5%
Gender (mention)	119	60.1%
Gender (emphasized)	117	59.1%
Class	17	8.6%
Rural/urban membership	15	7.6%
Age	21	10.6%
Ethnicity	7	3.5%
Total	198	100%

Drawing on Hall's (2017) position that media reflects societal perceptions of different social classes as much as it mirrors the absence of social categories coverage, the near-absence of class and ethnicity as analytical categories, as shown by these quantitative results, unveil how narrowly society views femicide through a very limited, obstructed lens. In this context, without a reflexive, comprehensive understanding of femicide, coverage will be limited in nuance, hence public awareness will also remain precarious and uneven.

Ahmed's (2007) conceptualization of whiteness as orientation becomes particularly relevant here through the near-complete erasure of ethnicity as a lens in coverage. Roma women—who have long been dehumanized and systemically concealed in media representations and institutional decisions alike (Durnescu, 2025; Voina and Sabău, 2025; Mózes, Klesch, and Feith, 2022)—are never mentioned explicitly in articles, with only 3.5% of the sample addressing ethnicity as a structural element of femicide. This reflects how whiteness structures the hierarchy of which women's deaths are deemed grievable and worthy of public attention, and whose remain invisible from mainstream coverage, only being considered by nonprofits and platforms of digital activism that do not garner equal traction, and even then, scarcely so.

Similarly, Wallis (2015) singles out class as a structural force, which here becomes obstructed both within the problem definition variable and the social category factoring into femicide prevalence valuable. The invisibility of class can be understood as a lack of acknowledgement of factors contributing to femicide, such as financial dependence, poverty, lack of access to a wide variety of resources, and so on.

Patterns become clearer through crosstabulations (Table 5). In the majority of articles (68.9%), the presence of structural factors—for which legal failure, misogynistic societal attitudes, access to resources, education for both citizens and authorities alike, patriarchal views were considered—coincided with the presence of gender, mentioned as gender-based violence, gender inequality, motherhood, etc. Similarly, articles that do not mention gender also largely dismissed structural factors (87.3%).

Table 5. Relationship between mentions of structural factors and mentions of gender

		Mention of gender		
		Absent	Present	Total
Mention of structural factors	Absent	87.3% (N=69)	31.1% (N=37)	53.5% (N=106)
	Present	12.7% (N=10)	68.9% (N=82)	46.5% (N=92)
	Total	100% (N=79)	100% (N=119)	100% (N=198)

Hamilton et al.'s (2019) concept of femininity premium sheds light on who is ascribed coverage: the women whose identity performance most aligns with the culturally dominant norms of femininity at that time. In this case, the victims who receive coverage the most receive an idealized victimhood portrayal due to their gender performance: they are often portrayed through their youthful age and motherhood or pregnancy status. They are more likely to be grieved publicly, while those who fall outside these norms—elderly women or sex workers, for example—are granted less or no visibility at all, or, alternatively, they are attributed a part of the responsibility of the crime.

The pattern repeats for gender as an emphasized factor (Figures 7 and 8): gender is emphasized largely in the articles that mention structural factors (82%). When gender is an emphasized factor, the problem is more likely to be defined as legal or institutional failure (50.4%), and the responsibility is assigned to the state or institutions (33.3%) or mixed (40.2%). The opposite occurs when gender is absent: responsibility is largely ascribed to the perpetrator, individually (67.9%), and the cause is either relationship conflict (53.1%) or personal (27.2%), attributed, again, to the perpetrator. Other social categories emphasized as factors—age, ethnicity, class, rural/urban lifestyle—behave alike, despite their deficient presence within the sample.

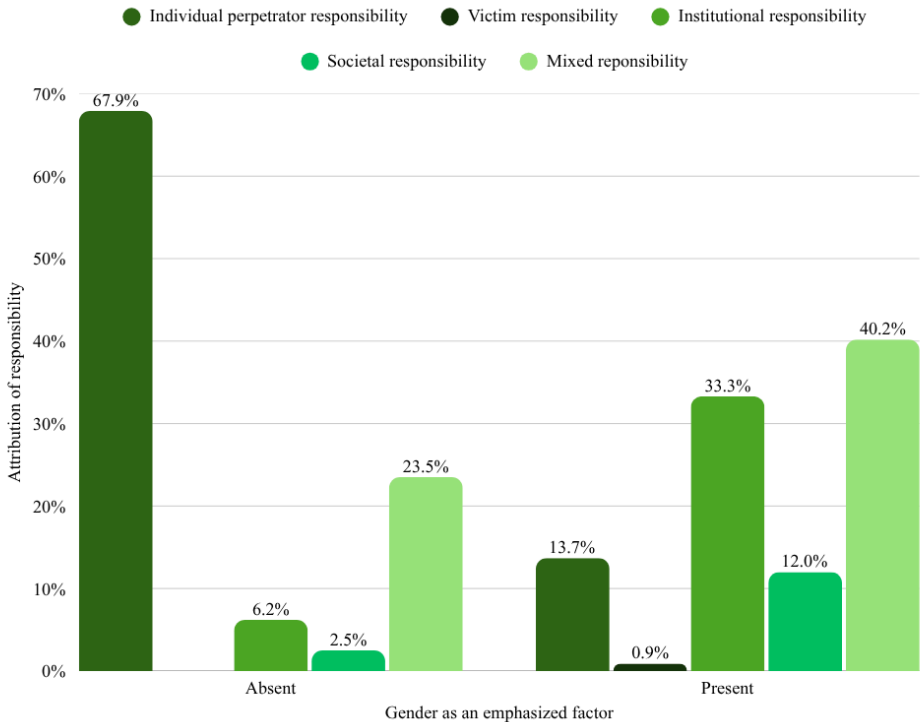


Figure 7. Correlations between responsibility attribution and gender presence across the sample (N=198)

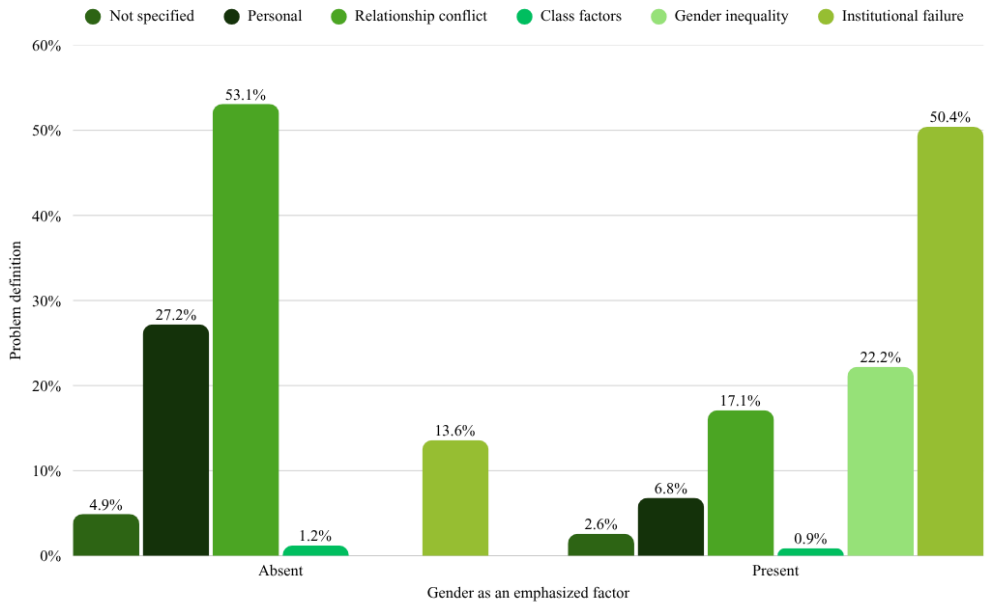


Figure 8. Correlations between problem definition and gender as a factor across the sample (N=198)

Returning to de Lauretis's argument that "violence is a sign of a power struggle for the maintenance of a certain kind of social order" (Breines & Gordon, 1983 cited in de Lauretis, 1989, p. 242), the selective visibility of structural factors in this sample reflects precisely that tension. The near-absence of class and ethnicity as analytical categories is not a neutral gap that happened incidentally. Instead, it is proof of a condition that maintains existing hierarchies by erasing certain ways in which some members of Romanian society are more vulnerable than others.

Cuklanz recognizes in this the ideological persistence of mainstream media as a site where meanings of gendered violence are reproduced—sometimes even as legal definitions evolve and apparent legislative progress is championed—as women are consistently seen and treated as "less than human" (Cuklanz, 2013, p. 32).

Moreover, taken together, Entman (1993) and Iyengar (1994) suggest that only if thematic framing and treatment responsibility become consistently dominant, will femicide news coverage create a significant shift in the public, steering it towards structural and intersectional understanding of the subject, and a reflexive awareness of it. Referring to these concepts, though, shows where these results are currently placed within a cycle of superficial recognition of femicide as a structural, intersectional, and political issue.

It would be perfunctory to state that intersectionality is absent in femicide coverage. Instead, it is more accurate to say that femicide is simply put recognized unevenly across social categories, with a particular tendency to dismiss class and ethnicity. As a consequence, structural violence becomes selectively visible.

Lastly, through crosstabulations of publication dates, structural factors, and emphasized social categories, results show that these elements are mentioned the most towards the end of 2025 (14.5% for articles published on November 10th 2025), when Case 51 happened. This birthed the hypothesis that femicide reporting becomes more structural and intersectional in time, which will be challenged when assessing cases 25, 28, and 51 in the qualitative stage of this research.

Consistent with Richards et al.'s (2011) discovery that intimate partner femicide often is seen through a societal lens and not a structural one, these results confirm that the recognition of femicide as a societal issue in Romanian media remains unevenly distributed across different

social categories, leading to social hierarchization and becoming symptomatic of intersectional blindness.

Increased visibility contradicts with weak structural understanding. Further confirming and deepening the understanding of this finding is done through the qualitative layer of this thesis. This stage is essential in exemplifying more specifically—beyond frequencies and high-level mapping—how meaning is constructed through frames.

Lastly, the quantitative results expose how femicide visibility has become a semantic reality in Romania, but despite that, it is still conceptually precarious. The terminology entered news coverage at the time of the first case analyzed in the next stage, but the quantitative patterns suggest that femicide cases maintained a largely episodic and authority-dominated framing. Sensationalism, structural shallowness, and idealized victimhood persisted, meanwhile intersectional factors were almost entirely absent. These findings underline a contradiction: while femicide gained exposure, the thorough understanding of what it entails did not manage to catch up to the rate at which visibility grew. In the following section, the qualitative stage offers depth to this analysis by examining how meaning is constructed through frames in the high-profile cases of 2025.

6.2. Qualitative results and analysis

In this section, the emerging frames will be outlined, defined, and analyzed, connecting their core characteristics with theoretical concepts.

6.2.1. Framing analysis overview

Femicide is constructed as a dramatic, emotionally immediate crime event, narrated through sensationalist language, the victim's identity markers, and step-by-step reconstruction of the act. The crime is rendered visible primarily through shock value, positioning the audience as witnesses to tragedy rather than citizens confronting a systemic pattern.

Legal and institutional failures are acknowledged, yet contained within the limits of the specific case. Blame cascades downward through authority tiers from high-level authority organs (ministers) to mid-level organs (regional courts of law), then low-level organs (local police),

each blaming the authority level below without reaching a structural critique of the system that produces those failures. In this case, reactive accountability replaces structural reform.

Femicide is narrated through a retrospective documentation of the victim's and perpetrator's personal histories, constructing moral legibility through identity performance. The victim must qualify as grievable through idealized femininity, while the perpetrator is pathologized as a deviant. Violence is explained through biography, not structure.

Femicide is positioned within a broader pattern of legal dysfunction, normalized domestic violence, and institutional neglect/unpreparedness. Expert and advocate voices introduce gender-based violence framing and educational discourse, pushing coverage toward treatment responsibility and opening space for structural critique, even if intersectional dimensions remain underdeveloped.

Femicide is framed as a phenomenon shaped by intersecting axes of power (gender, class, ethnicity, age, rural/urban location) with different social categories exposed to violence unevenly. This frame treats legal failure as symptomatic of deeper structural inequalities, not as an isolated dysfunction. Its near-absence in the sample is itself the central finding. Structural and intersectional recognition only shows up in one of the nine articles, yet its very scarcity represents an analytical finding, highlighting the gaps and limitations of conceptual visibility of femicide in Romanian news coverage.

Table 6. Dominant frames

Frame	**Dominant frames across sample**
F1: Femicide as spectacle	FA1, FA7
F2: Institutional failure as individualized dysfunction	FA4, FA6
F3: Moralized victimhood and deviant masculinity	FA2, FA8
F4: Femicide as preventable institutional failure	FA3, FA5
F5: Structural and intersectional recognition	FA9

The emerging frames were organized in a progressive spectrum depicting how close Romanian news coverage arrives to portraying femicide through a comprehensive lens.

At a glance, the qualitative findings of this research indicate a semantic increase of the word *femicide* and of public recognition of femicide. Institutional discourse seems stronger, especially compared to the near-total absence of femicide framing documented in the quantitative stage, where only one article from 2024 remained in the sample. Despite this, the in-depth framing analysis employed and the resulting frames showcase that episodic framing and individualization are still persisting, leading alongside a very limited conceptual and intersectional understanding of femicide. This indicates that the critical understanding of femicide in journalistic coverage could not keep up with the rapid pace at which femicide visibility increased—which, in turn, leaves compelling chasms in the public's reflexive awareness of femicide.

As Case 25 is the first major case that was framed publicly as a femicide, there is a gradual progression in case reporting and aftermath articles, because by Case 51, the language used in framing has developed. This is confirmed by quantitative findings, however, despite Case 51 having the most public attention as a femicide (10.11.2025 is the date with the most published articles in the sample), structural factors are still predominantly absent, and if they are present, they are not framed as weighing significantly in the rise of femicide cases.

6.2.2. Frame by frame analysis

Frame 1: Femicide as spectacle

Defined through the following core characteristics, articles FA1 and FA7 are dominated by the femicide as a spectacle frame, prioritizing moderately to highly sensationalist tones and dramatization, and emphasizing the motherhood status of the victim. While the voice of authorities is amplified and authority-centric narration occurs through local and regional institution representatives statements, the framing prioritizes emotional immediacy over factual evidence. The framing style is typically episodic, the cases being taken out of the context of a worrying pattern of growing femicide cases. When it comes to typology, FA1 and FA7 are both case reports.

This frame is consistent with Ittefaq's (2018) argument that sensationalism and clickbait function as indicators of newsworthiness in digital media environments. This is seen not only through the clickbait headlines, but also through the emotionally charged language that often employs stereotypical crime metaphors—for example "images are truly hair-raising" and "the man was hunting her" (FA1).

Turning to Surette's (2007) ideal victim trope, it is activated through the repeated emphasis on motherhood status, constructing conditional grievability rather than structural understanding. This spectacle of ideal victimhood is only amplified by the instrumentalization of the victims' children in reports: "holding her 3-year-old little girl in her arms" (FA1) or "everything happened under the eyes of their 3-year-old child" (FA7).

Echoing the very same observations as those generated from the quantitative findings, this frame further highlights how violence is inherently political and, as de Lauretis puts it, "en-gendered in representation" (de Lauretis, 1989, p. 240), while gender remains a condition impossible to bypass. This translates to a violent representation of victims of femicide even in news portrayals, their violent deaths being transformed in a spectacle for journalistic gain, reflecting how much the dehumanization of women is embedded into social and professional practices.

Moreover, Harcup and O'Neill's news values guide journalistic choices and shape how events are framed in order to exploit their newsworthiness potential. Elements such as exclusivity, conflict, and shareability are employed to create a certain framing in articles such as FA1 and FA7 through clickbait headlines, stereotypical buzzword metaphors, and sensationalist language. Celebrity is another element employed for its contribution to news value, with FA1 depicting Case 25 profiting off of the victim's public image as a former reality television star to increase newsworthiness. This only further dehumanizes victims and singles out the case instead of framing it in the context of a systemic pattern.

Frame 2: Institutional failure as individualized dysfunction

When it comes to the second frame, articles FA4 and FA6 are perfect illustrations of institutional failure framed as individualized dysfunction. The main characteristics of this frame are represented by the prioritization of authority-dominated narration and downward blame attribution with higher authorities blaming lower, local-level authorities, and local level

authorities themselves engaging in victim-blaming—exemplifid through police statements that highlighted the perpetrator's disobedience and the victim's indecisiveness ("there was a protection order issues, but it became inactive due to the victim revoking it" in FA4).

Other elements include case-contained institutional critique ("we will conduct internal investigations into the case afterwards" in FA6) and absence of systemic accountability ("According to Minister Predoiu, the domestic violence cases handled by IGPR were in 'quasi-totality solved'; and that „'here is a positive statistic that shows that the police intervened and protected in most other cases'" in FA6).

Moreover, the perpetrator and victim are even partially absorbing institutional blame: perpetrator breaching protection order and becoming a fugitive (FA4), victim denying domestic violence shelter (FA4), or victim being accused of helping the perpetrator flee (FA6). The dominant voice in this case is that of the authorities, contributing to an episodic framing style. This frame is present in the case reporting and aftermath of Case 28.

This frame represents a perfect illustration of how cascade activation can be applied to femicide coverage. High-level authorities (Internal Affairs Minister in FA6) assume accountability reactively and assign responsibility to lower-level actors within the authority hierarchy. The blame is shifted towards local authorities and civilians, even the victim herself, for having helped the perpetrator escape, while the high-level authorities assume the position of a corrective actor that orchestrates the investigation of individualized local and regional institutional failure.

Similarly, Iyengar's (1994) distinction between causal and treatment responsibility becomes, again, relevant. Here, responsibility shares a mix of causal and treatment. On the one hand, investigation into local-level misconduct or poor application of the law represents a form of treatment responsibility by ensuring corrections are made, yet, on the other hand, without thoroughly identifying the role of each institution or actor within the authority hierarchy, responsibility remains somewhat causal and pertaining to an individualized case.

This framing further echoes Surette's (2007) observations regarding representations of a faulty criminal justice system, where institutional shortcomings are personalized and dramatized without questioning the deeper social and structural conditions that sustain violence. Rather than

destabilizing institutional legitimacy, this frame ultimately reinforces it by constructing femicide as the result of isolated breakdowns within an otherwise functional system.

Frame 3: Moralized victimhood and deviant masculinity

Seen as containing a range of stereotypes, from victim-centric assumptions (ideal victim trope, emotional purification of the victim) to perpetrator-centric beliefs (pathologization or deviancy), the moralized victimhood and deviant masculinity frame is characterized through victim and perpetrator portrayal, as well as retrospective warning signs and relational dramatization.

The voice of witnesses dominates in FA2 and FA8—both of them relationship deep-dives—contributing to a highly emotional and dramatized episodic framing style.

Within this frame, victims are constructed through Hamilton et al.'s (2019) conception of idealized femininity, while perpetrators are framed as pathological, obsessive, deviant men. The concept of the femininity premium (Hamilton et al., 2019) becomes particularly visible here, as victimhood is legitimized through performances of socially valued femininity, especially motherhood, vulnerability, and emotional purity. In FA2, for example, the victim's past involvement in sex work is very carefully softened through previous televised statements and reframed in order to preserve her moral legitimacy and public worthiness to be grieved ("I was there for a few days [...] I don't think I would've continued anyway").

At the other end of the spectrum, perpetrators are individualized through narratives of abnormality and deviance, which shifts the violent act away from its structural understanding—and a deeper understanding of gender-based violence at large—toward the logic of exceptional male pathology. This reflects Cuklanz's (2013) argument about the individualization of violence and the replication of violence myths that detach abuse from the patriarchal system of gender inequality.

Additionally, this frame also reflects de Lauretis' understanding of violence as "en-gendered n representation" (de Lauretis, 1989, p. 245). Mirroring previous reflections over the quantitative findings, violence itself becomes reproduced symbolically through news portrayals here too. Victims become reduced to simplified emotional archetypes, while perpetrators are transformed into spectacles through their assumed deviance. Rolle et al.'s (2020) conceptualization of the

aestheticization becomes again relevant, as violence permeates the veil of storytelling through emotionally charged metaphors and other linguistic devices, denying victims of full subjectivity and instead, transforming their suffering and death into a consumable spectacle.

Ultimately, the moralized victimhood and deviant masculinity frame constructs femicide through a moral binary of innocent femininity and corresponding monstrous masculinity. This intensifies emotional engagement, yet simultaneously obstructs a structural and intersectional comprehension of violence.

Frame 4: Femicide as preventable institutional failure

Femicide as preventable institutional failure represents the frame that captures a change in the conceptual deliverance of femicide. Dominant in articles FA3 and FA5, its core characteristics encompass thematic framing, expert and advocate voice amplification, construction of femicide as gender-based violence, and femicide terminology used conceptually rather than just semantically. Through this frame, FA3 and FA5 both contain educational discourse about domestic violence victim behavior patterns, and treatment responsibility that opens structural space even if intersectional dimensions remain underdeveloped.

This frame reflects the counter-framing potential that was earlier identified in Xiong, Cho, and Boatwright's (2019) study of digital activism. Activist and expert voices challenge the dominating depoliticized portrayals of violence by including broader social and institutional contexts in their statements. Through these advocate and expert interventions, femicide is conceptualized further than the usual isolated crime framing: it is finally weaved into the tapestry of gender-based violence enabled by systemic disparities in victim protection, public education, legal enforcement training, and proper application of legislation.

Thematic framing becomes visible here, as the articles move beyond the immediate event and open structural spaces to discuss recurring institutional failures. Domestic violence becomes contextualized through recurring patterns of police and court negligence, lack of institutional preparedness, insufficient public awareness of protective measures, and mishandling of protective devices such as the ankle monitoring systems or restraining orders.

Similarly, Iyengar's (1994) treatment responsibility notion can be seen more clearly within the articles frames through the preventable institutional failure lens. Here, responsibility is directed towards institutions and legal systems, and solutions are discussed through actionable items: prevention mechanisms, legal reform, educational intervention, enforcement training, and so on. Yet, despite the structural opening, intersectional dimensions remain underdeveloped. Social categories—specifically ethnicity and class—are absent from the discussion and disconnected from femicide as a recurring societal pattern.

As a result, this frame encapsulates the clearest shift towards a structural recognition of femicide within this sample. But it also reveals at the same time the rigid limitations of Romanian femicide coverage in fully conceptualizing violence intersectionally.

Frame 5: Structural and intersectional recognition

Lastly, standing by itself within this sample, FA9 is the only article that exhibits a dominantly structural and intersectional framing, recognizing properly these factors as contributing to femicide. This frame's core characteristics encapsulate mentions of structural or intersectional factors, such as impact on different social categories, contextualization of the case within a larger pattern of femicide and gender-based violence, proof of ample understanding of the gaps in legal action, and mention of global trends and statistics related to femicide in order to place Romanian femicide cases within the wider map of gender-based violence.

As mentioned before, unlike the previous frames identified in this analysis, the structural and intersectional recognition frame showcases a reflexive understanding of femicide as a systemic and intersectional phenomenon—not a merely individualized instance of violence. The dominant voices in FA9 belong to advocates and experts in law and gender, as well as international academic voices. The framing style is thematic and the article belongs to the aftermath typology.

This frame reflects Collins and Bilge's (2020) conceptualization of intersectionality as an analytical tool, as it explicitly recognizes how certain social categories are more vulnerable than others in the context of femicide, and exposure to violence is unevenly distributed. Femicide is framed as violence shaped by overlapping systems of gender inequality, economic frailty, and institutional exclusion.

Similarly, Hall's (2017) understanding of representation and power is particularly relevant in this case, as even this frame that exhibits awareness still leaves out social categories within the general visibility. Some social categories are barely visible even when the subject is intersectionality: in this case, ethnicity is mentioned, but not Roma women explicitly, whose experiences remain unregistered outside of Roma advocate efforts, which dwells in and of itself in marginality. This finding only strengthens what Roma scholarship has long confirmed, namely the skewed dual representation of Roma women: completely erased in victimhood, yet hypervisible in criminality (Voina & Sabău, 2025).

This reverberates with concepts of visibility hierarchies and dominating whiteness (Ahmed, 2007), which explain how visibility is received by members of certain social categories and not by others, as well as whose vulnerability is assigned meaning and whose gets stripped away. Turning to Wallis's (2015) definition of class as a structural force rather than a descriptive trait, it becomes obvious in this case that class is hardly discussed as a contributing factor, despite being the red thread that binds femicide cases together. From lack of access to legal, educational, and financial resources, to financial dependence on their perpetrator, victims are often confounded in a violent living situation due to their membership to a lower socio-economic class. Not recognizing that layer of vulnerability leaves a considerable rift in authorities' ability to supply adequate help for victims of domestic violence.

Taken together across cases and article typologies, these frames reveal two meaningful patterns. Firstly, out of the three cases of the qualitative sample, none is covered in a coherent and consistent manner: each of them contains articles that embody multiple frames, despite some dominating over others. This signifies that Romanian news coverage constructs diverging understandings of the same femicide case based on article typology and dominant voice. Secondly, a tentative progression can be noticed across cases towards more structural framing—a shift that can be noticed the most in Case 51, which followed the other two cases, exhibiting the only case of F5 frame. However, this progress remains fragile and fragmentary, as even Case 51 contains all levels of framing, from F1 and F3 to F5, showing that even a case that contains structural framing can simultaneously be represented in coverage through sensationalist and spectacle framing.

This finding reveals that articles that prioritize advocate and expert voices live in a lane of evolution of their own, increasing in structural framing from Case 25's aftermath article FA3 employing the femicide as preventable institutional failure frame (F4) to Case 51's aftermath article FA9 reaching a structural and intersectional recognition frame (F5). Yet, the near-absence of F5 across this nine-article sample from the most visible femicide cases of 2025 suggests that increased visibility has not translated, in this case, to an in-depth conceptual understanding of femicide, and hence, it cannot build reflexive awareness of femicide in the public.

The five frames identified through the qualitative stage of analysis, taken together, reveal that Romanian femicide news coverage finds itself in a transitional moment starting 2025. As the language of structural critique has started forming, embedded traditions of spectacle, sensationalism, misplaced blame, and individualized institutional dysfunction still occupy a dominant spot in news coverage. The progression from F1 to F5, not linear throughout the sample, illustrates exactly that. Each article contains multiple frames, which reflects the contradictions at the heart of a media system caught between entrenched newsroom practices and growing pressures for change. The low presence of F5 is the most blatant sign that despite the increased visibility of femicide, structural and intersectional recognition is still scarce, being registered in only one article in the sample. This cannot be seen as incidental, as it is a symptom of deeply rooted conditions that will be addressed in the following Discussion chapter.

7. Discussion

This section will encompass the discussion of the previously relayed findings and connect them to the research aim and the two research questions that served as guidance throughout this thesis. The discussion will begin with a mapping of femicide visibility across Romanian online news, followed by an exploration of the frames emerged through the analysis—what they underline and what they hide, as well as what they are symptomatic of within the historic context of Romania's media system. The following sub-chapters address reflected ideologies and the significance of the findings in the larger context of previous scholarship. Limitations and challenges encountered throughout the research process are also addressed. Finally, the discussion ends with a look forward towards future research opportunities.

7.1. Mapping femicide visibility

At the very beginning of this thesis, one of the main missions embarked on was completing the labor of mapping femicide across Romanian online news in a way that has not been done before. Previous scholarship focused on individual femicide case framing (Balica, 2021, Rovenţa-Frumuşani and Stoica, 2023) and overall femicide case salience within news coverage in Romania (Badea, 2025)—which provided a very fruitful point of departure for this research—yet, because femicide was semantically and conceptually nearly nonexistent in news coverage, its very recent emergence and growing visibility had not yet been captured in academic research. In this sense, this thesis has achieved its aim.

Therefore, to properly answer the first research question—*How are femicide cases made visible and framed across Romanian online news media?*—Romanian femicide coverage was found to be largely made visible through spectacle and the moralized biographies of victims and perpetrators alike, with episodic framing still dominating even in high-profile cases.

The quantitative content analysis of a sample of 198 articles over a period of two years (2024 and 2025) revealed that on a semantic level, the word *femicide* has only become active in news coverage of national femicide cases starting with the high-profile June 2025 murder of reality television personality Teodora Marcu by her stalker former partner. Moreover, by adopting

variables pertaining to responsibility attribution, causality, victim and perpetrator portrayal, and structural and intersectional framing, the analysis showcased an overview rich in detail.

Most notably, despite the word *femicide* being used throughout the sample, with 53% of articles treating femicide as a central concept, episodic framing still dominated over 37.4% of the sample. To add to that, structural and intersectional factors were missing from over half of the sample (with factors such as class being 91.4% absent), a pattern that persisted even as terminology gained traction.

The mixed-methods research design enabled a mapping that offers breadth through the quantitative stage, but not without adding depth through the subsequent qualitative step. In this sense, beyond when, where, and how much femicide was made visible in news coverage, it became equally apparent how it was brought to light too. The results of the first analysis raised an important question regarding what kind of understanding this emerging visibility has produced, which is what the framing analysis helped answer.

7.2. Framing femicide

While mapping femicide visibility was instrumental to an understanding of the general comprehension of the term, the framing analysis fulfilled the essential role of adding a layer of depth to the first research question, as well as help answer the second. The second research question asked *How does Romanian news coverage of femicide frame the public understanding of femicide as a social issue?*, and the framing analysis showcased compelling nuances in the answer.

Increased exposure was captured through the previous quantitative stage and confirmed the persistence of voice dominance, victim and perpetrator portrayal stereotypes, and perceived causality, yet what the qualitative stage offered that was essential to the study was evidence that this exposure failed to translate to structural awareness. Instead, it led to a wider publicity of victim dehumanization.

Perhaps most jarring is the multitude of layers suffering unfolds in. This is thoroughly demonstrated through the five frames crystallized through the qualitative analysis: femicide as

spectacle (F1), institutional failure as individualized dysfunction (F2), moralized victimhood and deviant masculinity (F3), femicide as preventable institutional failure (F4), and structural and intersectional recognition (F5). Taken together, they reveal a spectrum of understanding that news coverage exposes its audience to. The domination of F1 and F3 captures the persistence of episodic framing, sensationalism, and individual blame attribution through emotional spectacle, dramatized victim and perpetrator biographies, and prioritization of moral judgment over structural context. F2 underlines the ways in which cases remain individualized particularly through authority voices, institutional failure being minimized until it reaches the level of singular dysfunction, obscuring the larger systemic context entirely.

On the other hand, the least salient frames F4 and F5 illustrate incipient shifts in femicide portrayal. F4 showcases limited conditions for the development of reflexive public understanding of femicide as a systemic issue, which lead to a very fragile, fragmentary, and uneven perception among the Romanian audience at large. As Entman argues, frames, beyond simply reflecting reality, construct it actively by pushing forward some elements and obscuring others (Entman, 1993), either knowingly or as a result of long traditions of embedded oblivion to marginalized social categories. In the sample analyzed in this thesis, the spectacle of individual tragedy is what is consistently made salient, while the structural violence that produces femicide remains widely invisible.

In the same vein, hierarchical media visibility displays whose femicide is deemed deserving of coverage and whose stays undocumented. Combining Hamilton et al.'s (2019) concept of femininity premium with Ahmed's (2007) conceptualization of whiteness as an orientation, the findings unveil that grievability is conditional and contingent on the victim's performance of idealized femininity. As seen in the analysis, this is frequently expressed through highlighting the victim's motherhood status. Women whose identities fall outside these norms receive either less or no visibility, or framing that implicitly attributes responsibility to them.

Most blatantly, Roma women are entirely absent from the sample, with ethnicity only having been mentioned in 3.5% of the quantitative sample and only once within the qualitative sample, not having been analytically connected to differential vulnerability at either stage of the analysis. Even when ethnicity was mentioned, Roma women were not distinctly named. This can only be

perceived as a structural condition that reproduces the very hierarchies of value that make certain women more exposed to domestic violence and femicide, while simultaneously rendering their deaths less grievable. This resonates with Hall's (2017) argument that media is an active participant in the reproduction of social hierarchies, not just a disconnected mirror that merely reflects them.

Compared to previous studies of femicide coverage in Romania, this thesis strengthens existing findings by testing them in the new, surging context of increased semantic visibility and partial conceptual exposure. Femicide is by definition an inherently intersectional and systemic issue, but these dimensions rarely live in Romanian news coverage because of a legacy of gender stereotypes, ideal victimhood or aggressor deviance tropes, as well as a strong exploitation of spectacle and sensationalism, individualized portrayals, causal responsibility, and weak structural contexts.

The results of both analyses complete each other in signaling an ongoing shift through partially structural elements and transitional expert discourse, where institutions begin to be framed more frequently as active actors in femicide. However, because their voice still dominates, a cascade activation happens, where actors with higher levels of authority assign blame and responsibility to local authorities that often do not receive the educational resources and financial incentives to perform more adequately.

All in all, due to the sequential mixed-methods design applied (essential in achieving the aim of the thesis), the gap in research of femicide coverage in Romania could be filled. The quantitative stage architectured the map of femicide visibility, and the framing analysis added upon that result by revealing what that visibility actually produces.

As the analyses reveal, for now, the semantic presence of femicide throughout news coverage is not too dissimilar to an analgesic administered too late to Romanian society.

7.3. Reflected ideologies

Tuning into the social constructivist core of this study, one stratified way of answering the second research question is through the ideologies that are reflected in the results of the analyses, particularly in the frames that emerged during the qualitative step.

Contextualized within Romania's unique media system—brimming, as shown in the Background section, with corruption and ethical lapses in newsroom practices amplified by digitalization and algorithmic prioritization (Botan, 2024)—these framing patterns get to persist structurally because of the deprofessionalized nature of this very environment. In other words, how femicide is framed in news articles is not a matter of individual or even outlet-specific journalistic failure. It is the consequence of an eroded media system whose rifts in journalistic integrity are structurally incompatible with reflexive awareness.

Furthermore, this dynamic is very apparent in the way authority voices respond to femicide only as cases reach sufficient traction through advocate and protester pressure. Illustrating a cascading activation of hierarchical power voices (Entman, 2024), the reactive accountability of institutions manifests as a blame-shifting downward spiral, with the highest tiers of authority actors blaming regional and local institutions, which then pass down the blame to local police enforcement and even the victim, the perpetrator, or the witnesses of the crime themselves.

As a result, no tier acknowledges complete responsibility of the crime and recognizes wholly the systemic conditions that produced the institutional failure. Instead, institutions maintain their position of dominance in interpreting femicide publicly, even as they keep deflecting structural critique from advocates against gender-based violence. As such, the pattern is reproduced time and time again, without any actor in power challenging the ideological framework that enables the violence to persist.

From another point of view, while this thesis does not aim to test the projection of reflexive awareness upon the audience through femicide news coverage, it is likely that such a profound comprehension of femicide is still lacking. Reflexive awareness of femicide as a structural and intersectional issue cannot rise from a maintained tradition of blame-shifting. Ideally, it would be manifested in news coverage by positioning the public as citizens confronting a social problem that they become collectively aware of. Yet, current coverage still largely portrays femicide cases as individual tragedies, where the public is nudged to occupy a witness position in.

The mere presence of activist and expert voices in news coverage is a device used to manufacture the illusion of episodic frame counteraction, yet even these low, inconsistent, and inconspicuous inclusions still exist within a pattern of sensationalism, idealized victimhood, and

pursuits of newsworthiness. As Xiong, Cho, and Boatwright (2019) point out, feminist digital activism has the potential to bring to light counter-frames that openly question systemic patterns, but even in this context, there is a strong disconnect between activist voice and journalistic practices. This analysis suggests that, for now, this potential of activist voices has not yet fully pervaded into editorial practices in a meaningful and enduring way.

7.4. Importance of findings

The analytical look into femicide visibility within Romanian news coverage achieved by this thesis—through the most optimistic lens—leads to the realization that a budding shift is slowly showing itself. Yet, seen as happening within a deprofessionalized media environment, it is not too distrustful to question whether framing and editorial practices themselves will be able to catch up to advocate pressures for social and structural recognition of femicide. It is natural to doubt a positive change in the superficial accountability of authorities on all levels, especially the highest, because, after all, journalistic framing often only emulates societal realities set by systems of power.

Growing digital activism may be a sign pointing to increased pressure on authorities for legal and political progress, yet the low trust in media (Botan, 2024) raises the valid concern that this historically dysfunctional system will be maintained.

The findings surrounding dramatization, victim dehumanization, and spectacle confirm that such framing elements keep being prioritized with the purpose of algorithmic amplification. This hinders the understanding of femicide as a politicized concept. The inclusion of experts in the articles underlines the necessity for a self-aware authority system that educates professionals to identify and properly treat domestic violence. This does not stop at legal institutions: it refers to journalistic training and professionalization too, so that depiction of issues such as domestic violence, gender-based violence, and femicide can become accurate and fair in representation. After all, media portrayals shape societal ideologies and reflexive awareness, as well as the sustenance of updated value systems that benefit and support victims.

Results mirror the paradox described by both Gillespie et al. (2013) and Aldrete and Fernández-Ardèvol (2023): visibility cannot translate to structural framing by itself. As episodic

frames prevail even within articles whose editorial choices prioritizes a more structural understanding of femicide as a concept, the analysis proves that exposure increase rests scant in the context of reframing embedded legacies of journalistic practices and media-diffused ideologies.

On the whole, the findings of this thesis contribute by adding a missing piece to the puzzle of femicide news coverage patterns in Romania through an empirically grounded exploration of femicide news framing at a moment of historical significance: the emergence of femicide as a named concept in Romanian public discourse, providing a foundation for extensive and comparative research in an otherwise academically under-represented context.

7.5. Limitations

Upon reflecting transparently on the research journey and its challenges, there are several limitations to take into consideration when interpreting the findings.

Because of the lack of extensive coverage of femicide cases using femicide terminology during the chosen timeframe, the qualitative sample can be considered small. However, since the cases selected were the only femicide cases that received intense coverage as instances of femicide, the sampling rationale favored the identification of different article typologies—case reportings, relationship deep-dives, and aftermath—for an insightful analysis of emerging frames. Topicality, terminology, and article type was prioritized consciously over a larger sample consisting of cases that were either not clearly defined as femicides or that preceded the chosen timeframe.

Developments in femicide coverage are still in their budding stage, which can represent both a fruitful opportunity for academic insights—noticing femicide frames in new coverage experience a shift and enter a transitory stage—and a slightly obstructed view over how this transition will evolve.

Another factor that should be considered is that television consumption still dominates audience behavior patterns in Romanian media (Marincea, 2023). Therefore, inclusion of television

coverage of femicide could have added significantly to this research, yet limited access to resources rendered this choice unfeasible.

Additionally, a potential limitation is that some variables—such as dominant voice—could be more stratified to add depth to the otherwise replicable model: for example, authority voices can be split into tiers of power.

Lastly, political communication around femicide was not a particular focus in this thesis—save for the presence of political voices in news articles—because of the desire to keep the study's aim orderly, and because of the limited timeframe of femicide visibility available.

When it comes to challenges encountered throughout the research process, the nature of the topic and material brought several ones. Engaging analytically with material that documents (often sensationally) the violent deaths of women required continuous reflexive awareness of the researcher's own position. The emotional weight of the topic was documented in the reflexive journal.

7.6. Future research

Glancing ahead, there are bountiful research opportunities surrounding femicide news coverage in Romania and similarly under-researched Eastern European and Balkan media systems. As semantic and conceptual presence of femicide in Romanian news is a very current development, there is a great potential for future research to approach a close examination of different stages in femicide coverage in Romanian media, perhaps looking at coverage of femicide cases preceding the terminological adoption of the word *femicide* and outlining a web of progression in which high-profile cases can be placed.

For a more granular inspection of femicide framing, future research could cross-analyze conceptual progress in the framing of femicide cases and shifts in voice dominance, particularly in relation to advocate voices. Comparative studies examining femicide coverage in other post-communist countries to highlight differences in journalistic norms and diverging media systems would equally increase knowledge in a rather precarious academic area.

As this study did not assess audience reaction, future research projects could assess public reaction through an analysis of online comment sections. Digital activism platforms—either standalone or occupying social media channels—would represent a very potent source of reactions to the framing of femicide cases and even negotiations of how femicide is comprehended conceptually. Similarly, a cross-analysis of digital activism coverage and expert voice representation in traditional news coverage would add depth to existing scholarship.

8. Conclusion

This thesis emerged from the ambitious aim of mapping femicide visibility in Romanian online news coverage and fill a gap in understanding how recently surged femicide terminology is used in the framing of killings of women, and what these frames reveal about the structural and intersectional understanding of femicide as a politicized concept in a unique, under-researched media context.

Serving as guide, two research questions were posed: how femicide cases are made visible and framed across Romanian online news media (RQ1) and how this coverage frames public understanding of femicide as a social issue (RQ2). These questions traced the path from surface-level semantic visibility to more profound questions of what that visibility offers the audience in terms of conceptual understanding.

In order to fulfill its mission, on a methodological level, the sequential mixed-methods design of this research combined the quantitative content analysis of 198 articles published in 2024 and 2025 with the framing analysis of nine articles drawn from the three high-profile femicide cases of 2025. The quantitative stage helped map the breadth of femicide coverage, upon which the qualitative stage added depth by identifying the five dominant frames used to construct meaning around femicide.

The results showed that Romanian femicide coverage is made visible primarily through spectacle, idealized victimhood, and episodic institutional blame, which ultimately contain femicide within the limits of singled out tragedy instead of systemic violence. Limited structural and intersectional activation in the articles points to the realization that increased visibility has not managed to push structural understanding forward. In other words, the word *femicide* has entered Romanian news, but without structural and intersectional framing, reflexive public awareness is nearly impossible to build.

This echoes the visibility paradox identified by Aldrete and Fernández-Ardèvol (2023) and Gillespie et al. (2013) to a national context where it has not previously been documented empirically. These findings contribute to a methodological foundation for future research into femicide framing in Romania and other post-communist media systems alike.

It is, however, essential to remember that behind the numbers, frequencies, and coded frames, there stands a cold reality of women having been killed. The three high-profile cases—identified through their corresponding number in a web of murders that has since 2025 grown—were the 25th, 28th, and 51st reminder, as each month of 2025 passed, that women are killed by men who have shown repeatedly before that they would. The systemic failures that surround these deaths were never exceptional. They were structural, and behind them stood other women whose deaths did not even make the news. They build a public record of lives considered worth protecting, grieving, even worthy of a number.

As femicide coverage is at the moment in its humble beginnings, it is important to identify how uneven framing can lead to fragmentary public awareness of what femicide, gender-based violence, and domestic violence entail. The numbers will keep growing, but whether the frames change is, in no small part, a question about whose death journalism decides to cover and how.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Brief introduction of the three high-profile femicide cases analyzed in the qualitative stage of the thesis

- Case 25:

Teodora Marcu, a 23-year-old woman, was killed by her former partner, Robert Lupu, in Bucharest on the evening of May 31st 2025. The case received significant national media attention due to the public nature of the attack and the victim's previous visibility as a reality television personality. Coverage frequently emphasized her motherhood status and personal history, while also raising discussions surrounding stalking, obsessive behavior, and the institutional handling of domestic violence and protection measures.

- Case 28:

Anda Gyurca was killed by her partner, Emil Gânj, in Târgu Mureș in July 2025 following a documented history of domestic violence. Media reports highlighted the perpetrator's prior violent behavior and criminal background, as well as previous interactions with authorities. The case generated discussions regarding repeated domestic abuse, failures in protection mechanisms, and the normalization of violence within intimate relationships. Emil Gânj is still a fugitive.

- Case 51:

Mihaela Mitrache was killed by her partner Gheorghe in Teleorman County in November 2025 in a case strongly connected to domestic violence and institutional failure. The perpetrator had previously been subject to legal restrictions and monitoring measures, including an electronic ankle monitor. The case sparked widespread public debate, protests, and institutional responses concerning the effectiveness of protection orders, police intervention, and state responsibility in preventing femicide.

Appendix 2: Quantitative content analysis codebook

Article ID: A1-A198

Publication date: DD/MM/YYYY

Outlet (1-27 in the following order): Adevărul, Click, Context, EVZ, HotNews, KanalD/KanalD2, NewsWeek, Observator News, PressOne, Republica, Snoop, SpotMedia, Știrile ProTV, TVR Info, Antena 3 CNN, B1TV, CanCan, Digi24, G4Media, Gândul, Libertatea, Mediafax, Realitatea, RomâniaTV, Scena9, WowBiz, Ziare

Outlet type: mainstream (1), independent (2), tabloid (3), television-affiliated (4)

Femicide prominence: not mentioned (0), in headline (1), central framing concept (2), limited use (3)

Reference scope: single case (1), case cluster (2), femicide as a wave (3)

Frame type: episodic (1), thematic (2), mixed (3)

Attribution of responsibility: none (0), perpetrator (1), victim (2), state/institutions (3), society/culture (4), mixed (5)

Problem definition (cause): not specified (0), personal/individual (1), relationship conflict (2), class factors (3), gender inequality/gender-based violence (4), legal/institutional failure (5)

Victim portrayal: absent (0), ideal victim (1), neutral (2), indirect blame (3), direct blame (4)

Perpetrator portrayal: absent (0), monster/deviant (1), sympathetic/humanized (2), neutral (3)

Tone: neutral (0), moderately sensationalist (1), highly sensationalist (2)

Mention of structural factors / gender (explicitly) / gender, class, rural/urban membership, age, ethnicity as contributing factor, respectively: absent (0), present (1)

Dominant voice: none (0), authorities (1), political or public figures (2), experts (3), activists or protesters (4), witnesses or perpetrator/victim statements (5)

Appendix 3: Example of a translated article (FA2)

Teodora debuted in a video chat studio under the guidance of her executioner: ”It wasn't something that I enjoyed very much. I went for a few days”

Teodora Marcu was sexually exploited by Robert Lupu in a video chat studio in Onești. He was suspected by the police in two pandering cases. “It wasn’t something I liked very much,” recounted the young woman on Temptation Island.

According to the judicial sources cited by Gândul, Robert Lupu was investigated in the past in two cases of pandering. He was 49 years old and had met Teodora Marcu when she was 14. Teodora decided to end the relationship, but the man started stalking her and sending her death threats.

Teodora talked on the TV show Temptation Island about the time where she partook in video chatting.

“It’s true. (...) I came clean about it and he (Alex, her husband) was bothered by it. But I did not actually partake in video chatting, I only wanted to see what happened there and what it truly was. I was there for a few days. I stopped before seeing Alex. (...) I was thinking I might or might not keep it up… It wasn’t something I enjoyed very much. (...) You don’t have to undress if you don’t want to. I don’t think I would’ve continued anyway. I really wanted to see how it was,” recounted the young woman.

Robert Lupu wrote about the Onești video chat studio in a manuscript titled “The life of a tramp and his analyses”.

“I’m gathering all my video chat equipment and leaving for Onești. She calls to tell me she’ll do everything that I didn’t want (a child, marriage, a home) with him. They get married, move to Brașov together, starting an apparently happy life, but not before issuing a 4-month court restraining order against me, alongside a lawsuit accusing me of unlawful entry, battering, and stealing a computer with cyber fraud,” wrote Robert Lupu.

The criminal was investigated for pandering in two cases. According to the cited publication, the first case was opened in 2012, when a person whose identity remains anonymous approached the police and claimed that Robert Lupu is managing multiple beautiful women who practice prostitution for him.

Multiple women were heard, as well as supposed clients. However, none of the young women admitted to prostitution, and the clients as well refused to admit the fact that they paid for sexual services. Therefore, the case was dropped.

During 2019, the police registered a new complaint about Robert Lupu being a pimp. Once again, the claim could not be proven.

The wrongful past of the criminal
Investigators discovered shocking information about the past of the man who shot Teodora March dead, Saturday evening, in a residential neighborhood north of the capital.

The individual received a four-month suspended prison sentence in April 2025 from a Milan Court for attempted theft or preparation to commit theft. He was also investigated in multiple criminal cases.

The young woman had a protection order against him in 2021, when she lived in Bacău. Between February and June 2021 there was a protection order against him emitted by the Bacău Court, with no registered breach, claim sources close to the investigation.

Subsequently, the young woman moved from Bacău county and did not request a new protection order after the initial one expired. Bacău County Police Inspectorate (CPI) was not notified about a possible conflict between the two.

Robert Lupu, the man who shot Teodora Marcu, was captured by surveillance footage fleeing the scene of the crime. He had two guns on him, neither of which he has a permit for.

The woman, who was pregnant, later passed away at the hospital. After the horrible gesture, the attacker ran to hide.

He was found approximately 3 hours later, but he had committed suicide before police officers managed to immobilize him. The man, who had two lethal guns on him, shot himself in the head. He did not shoot at law enforcement, and they did not use weapons against him.

Appendix 4: Questions guiding framing analysis coding:

- What is the dominant voice?
- What is the headline tone?
- What is the overall tone?
- What is the central narrative?
- What is made visible?
- What is omitted?
- Who defines the crime?
- How is violence defined?
- How is the victim constructed?
- How is the perpetrator constructed?
- How is the relationship between the victim and the perpetrator constructed?
- Is framing episodic or thematic?

- Is responsibility causal or treatment?
- Are social categories activated analytically?

Appendix 5: Additional cross-tabulation tables

Appendix 5.1. Correlations between responsibility attribution and gender presence

		Mention of gender		
		Absent	Present	Total
Attribution of responsibility	Individual	68.4% (N=54)	14.3% (N=17)	35.9% (N=71)
	Victim	0% (N=0)	0.8% (N=1)	0.5% (N=1)
	Institutions	6.3% (N=5)	32.8% (N=39)	22.2% (N=44)
	Society	2.5% (N=2)	11.8% (N=14)	8.1% (N=16)
	Mixed	22.8% (N=18)	40.3% (N=48)	33.3% (N=66)
	Total	100% (N=79)	100% (N=119)	100% (N=198)

Appendix 5.2. Correlations between problem definition and mentions of gender

		Mention of gender		
		Absent	Present	Total
Problem definition	Not specified	5.1% (N=4)	2.5% (N=3)	3.5% (N=7)
	Personal	27.8% (N=22)	6.7% (N=8)	15.2% (N=30)
	Relationship conflict	51.9% (N=41)	18.5% (N=22)	31.8% (N=63)
	Class factors	1.3% (N=1)	0.8% (N=1)	1.0% (N=2)
	Gender inequality	0% (N=0)	21.8% (N=26)	13.1% (N=26)
	Institutional failure	13.9% (N=11)	49.6% (N=59)	35.4% (N=70)
	Total	100% (N=79)	100% (N=119)	100% (N=198)

Appendix 5.3. Correlations between responsibility attribution and gender as an emphasized factor

		Mention of gender		
		Absent	Present	Total
Attribution of responsibility	Individual	67.9% (N=55)	13.7% (N=16)	35.9% (N=71)
	Victim	0% (N=0)	0.9% (N=1)	0.5% (N=1)
	Institutions	6.2% (N=5)	33.3% (N=39)	22.2% (N=44)
	Society	2.5% (N=2)	12% (N=14)	8.1% (N=16)
	Mixed	23.5% (N=19)	40.2% (N=47)	33.3% (N=66)
	Total	100% (N=81)	100% (N=117)	100% (N=198)

Appendix 5.4. Correlations between problem definition and gender as an emphasized factor

		Mention of gender		
		Absent	Present	Total
Problem definition	Not specified	4.9% (N=4)	2.6% (N=3)	3.5% (N=7)
	Personal	27.2% (N=22)	6.8% (N=8)	15.2% (N=30)
	Relationship conflict	53.1% (N=43)	17.1% (N=20)	31.8% (N=63)
	Class factors	1.2% (N=1)	0.9% (N=1)	1.0% (N=2)
	Gender inequality	0% (N=0)	22.2% (N=26)	13.1% (N=26)
	Institutional failure	13.6% (N=11)	50.4% (N=59)	35.4% (N=70)
	Total	100% (N=81)	100% (N=117)	100% (N=198)